

## PYP subjects

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## **Primary Years Programme PYP subjects**

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## IB mission statement

The International Baccalaureate aims to develop inquiring, knowledgeable and caring young people who help to create a better and more peaceful world through intercultural understanding and respect.

To this end the organization works with schools, governments and international organizations to develop challenging programmes of international education and rigorous assessment.

These programmes encourage students across the world to become active, compassionate and lifelong learners who understand that other people, with their differences, can also be right.



# IB learner profile

The aim of all IB programmes is to develop internationally minded people who, recognizing their common humanity and shared guardianship of the planet, help to create a better and more peaceful world.

As IB learners we strive to be:

## INQUIRERS

We nurture our curiosity, developing skills for inquiry and research. We know how to learn independently and with others. We learn with enthusiasm and sustain our love of learning throughout life.

## KNOWLEDGEABLE

We develop and use conceptual understanding, exploring knowledge across a range of disciplines. We engage with issues and ideas that have local and global significance.

## THINKERS

We use critical and creative thinking skills to analyse and take responsible action on complex problems. We exercise initiative in making reasoned, ethical decisions.

## COMMUNICATORS

We express ourselves confidently and creatively in more than one language and in many ways. We collaborate effectively, listening carefully to the perspectives of other individuals and groups.

## PRINCIPLED

We act with integrity and honesty, with a strong sense of fairness and justice, and with respect for the dignity and rights of people everywhere. We take responsibility for our actions and their consequences.

## OPEN-MINDED

We critically appreciate our own cultures and personal histories, as well as the values and traditions of others. We seek and evaluate a range of points of view, and we are willing to grow from the experience.

## CARING

We show empathy, compassion and respect. We have a commitment to service, and we act to make a positive difference in the lives of others and in the world around us.

## RISK-TAKERS

We approach uncertainty with forethought and determination; we work independently and cooperatively to explore new ideas and innovative strategies. We are resourceful and resilient in the face of challenges and change.

## BALANCED

We understand the importance of balancing different aspects of our lives—intellectual, physical, and emotional—to achieve well-being for ourselves and others. We recognize our interdependence with other people and with the world in which we live.

## REFLECTIVE

We thoughtfully consider the world and our own ideas and experience. We work to understand our strengths and weaknesses in order to support our learning and personal development.

The IB learner profile represents 10 attributes valued by IB World Schools. We believe these attributes, and others like them, can help individuals and groups become responsible members of local, national and global communities.

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# Introduction

The subject guidance in the Primary Years Programme (PYP) consists of the following resources.

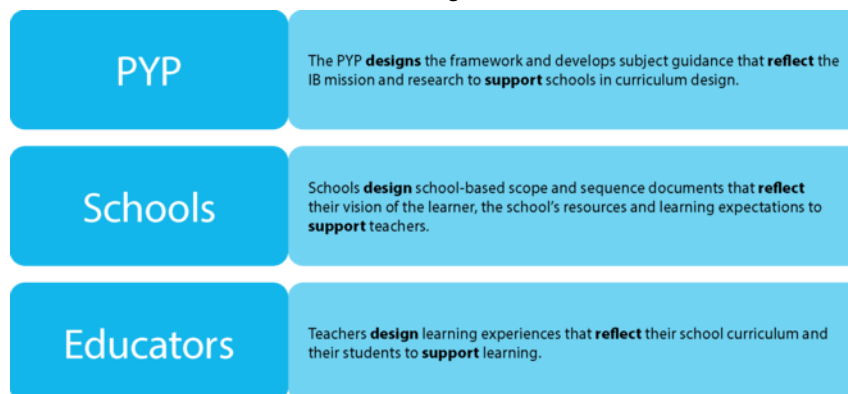
- Subject overviews for arts, language, mathematics, personal, social and physical education, science, social studies
- Subject continuums for arts, language, mathematics, Personal, social and physical education, science, social studies
- Additional language(s) resources

The PYP is a transdisciplinary curriculum framework used by schools to shape the International Baccalaureate (IB) philosophy to their own context by aligning their purpose, culture, environment, and learning (*Programme standards and practices*, 2020). The framework is described through *Primary Years Programme: From principles into practice* (2025).

The IB sees schools as designers of their own curriculum and educators as designers of their students' learning. The subject guidance supports the agency of educators as designers and the agency of students as they progress through their learning. The PYP provides guidance on how to design a programme of inquiry in the *Primary Years Programme: From principles into practice* > **"A transdisciplinary programme of inquiry"**.

Figure 1

Curriculum design in schools



The subjects are threaded through the six transdisciplinary themes, enabling students to appreciate the richness of diverse knowledge domains. Educators collaborate to facilitate inquiry by identifying authentic opportunities for learners to think, respond, and make connections within, across and beyond the subjects.

A school curriculum uses subjects to group learning outcomes and learning standards. The naming and description of these subjects vary across local and national curriculums. The PYP framework does not prescribe the subjects that PYP schools include in their curriculum and leave that open for schools to decide.

The programme standards and practices set out expectations for schools in their curriculum design. See the standard: Designing a coherent curriculum (0401) in IB *Programme standards and practices*.



# Subjects in the PYP

The subjects and their strands, supported by the PYP are as follows.

| Subject                                                                                                                                                 | Strand                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Arts</b><br><a href="#">Subject overview</a><br><a href="#">Subject continuums: Arts</a>                                                             | <p>Through the strands of <b>creating</b> and <b>responding</b>, arts describes the development of the following.</p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• <b>Dance:</b> expressing oneself through movement.</li> <li>• <b>Drama:</b> expressing oneself physically and vocally to convey emotional or cultural meaning.</li> <li>• <b>Music:</b> communicating in unique ways, bringing people and communities together.</li> <li>• <b>Visual arts:</b> exploring ways to make and create meaning in response to the varied and diverse messages in the world around us.</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| <b>Language</b><br><a href="#">Subject overview</a><br><a href="#">Subject continuums: Language</a><br><a href="#">Additional language(s) resources</a> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• <b>Oral language—listening and speaking:</b> as receptive and expressive skills, oral language involves developing language for both learning and relating to others.</li> <li>• <b>Visual language—viewing and presenting:</b> navigating, interpreting, using, and constructing multimodal text in various situations, understanding how images and language interact to convey ideas, values, and beliefs.</li> <li>• <b>Written language—reading:</b> constructing meaning from text through an interactive process, becoming competent, motivated, and independent readers.</li> <li>• <b>Written language—writing:</b> expressing oneself in visible, multimodal ways, with writing growing and developing as a personal act.</li> </ul> <p><b>Additional languages:</b> building and extending on these skills to support multilingualism through the areas of <b>interaction, culture and identity</b> and <b>text construction</b>.</p> |
| <b>Mathematics</b><br><a href="#">Subject overview</a><br><a href="#">Subject continuums: Mathematics</a>                                               | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• <b>Data handling:</b> analysing, making inferences about, and drawing conclusions from what we know about the world.</li> <li>• <b>Measurement:</b> exploring length, area, mass, capacity, money, temperature, and time.</li> <li>• <b>Shape and space:</b> understanding how objects relate to one another, and having an awareness of location, position and direction.</li> <li>• <b>Pattern and function:</b> making sense of the world by recognizing repetitive features, which enables generalizations foundational to algebraic reasoning and supports the development of computational fluency and computational thinking.</li> <li>• <b>Number:</b> using symbols and words to represent and describe quantity, communicate mathematical concepts and skills, and interpretations and decisions during problem-solving and investigations.</li> </ul>                                                                                 |

| Subject                                                                                                                                                           | Strand                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Personal, social and physical education</b><br><a href="#">Subject overview</a><br><a href="#">Subject continuums: Personal, social and physical education</a> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• <b>Identity:</b> understanding who we are, including our values, attitudes, beliefs, experiences, skills, abilities, emotions, and the impact of growth, cultural heritage and social environment.</li> <li>• <b>Interactions:</b> understanding how individuals and groups interact with each other, other living things, and the local and global environment.</li> <li>• <b>Wellness:</b> developing and maintaining a balanced, healthy lifestyle and taking action for healthy living now and in the future.</li> <li>• <b>Movement:</b> understanding health-related fitness outcomes and the body's unlimited potential for expression through movement, active play, and physical activity.</li> </ul> |
| <b>Science</b><br><a href="#">Subject overview</a><br><a href="#">Subject continuums: Science</a>                                                                 | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• <b>Living things:</b> exploring the sustainability, complexity, and interconnectedness of life on our planet.</li> <li>• <b>Earth and space:</b> exploring the structure of our planet and its position in the solar system, and how the properties, characteristics, and changes of our planet shape it.</li> <li>• <b>Physics and chemical science:</b> exploring physical and chemical objects, materials, and matter, and the ways in which people design technologies, and reflect on their potential impact on society and the environment.</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                   |
| <b>Social studies</b><br><a href="#">Subject overview</a><br><a href="#">Subject continuums: Social studies</a>                                                   | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• <b>Ways of knowing and systems:</b> exploring multiple ways of knowing and how past and present systems and structures impact human decision-making.</li> <li>• <b>Critical global citizenship and culture:</b> exploring ways in which people connect and appreciate each other, confront inequity, and engage with ideas in local and global contexts.</li> <li>• <b>Continuity and change for reimagined futures:</b> exploring time, place, and space in past, present, and future contexts.</li> <li>• <b>Interconnected places, spaces and relationships:</b> exploring people's sense of place and connection to both social and ecological contexts.</li> </ul>                                        |

These subjects, and the disciplines they connect to, support the foundational knowledge, skills, and concepts that can be developed through a transdisciplinary programme of inquiry.

For more information, refer to *Primary Years Programme: From principles into practice* > “A transdisciplinary programme of inquiry” > “The role of subjects”.

# Curriculum resources to support the subjects

## Subject overviews

The subject overviews describe the role of each subject in an inquiry-based transdisciplinary programme by:

- explaining concepts from the perspective of each subject, and providing examples of questions which help explore the concepts from subject-specific perspectives
- supporting understandings of agency and action for both the learner and educator
- providing examples of action
- showing how the wider learning community might be involved
- illustrating how the IB continuum builds on the subjects in the PYP.

## Subject continuums

The subject continuums outline the essential learning and teaching elements for each subject, including:

- descriptions of the subject strands
- overall expectations for each strand
- subject examples of phase-based subject continuums describing conceptual understandings and learning outcomes by phases.

## Other resources

These curriculum resources are supported by the following resources.

- A curriculum toolkit to support designing and evaluating curriculum
- Learning progressions for inquiry to support pedagogy
- Teacher support materials (TSMs) developed with schools and providing examples of practice

## Further reading

International Baccalaureate. (2020). *Programme standards and practices*. International Baccalaureate Organization.

International Baccalaureate. (2025) *Primary Years Programme: From principles into practice, Learning and teaching, A transdisciplinary programme of inquiry; The role of subjects*. International Baccalaureate Organization.

International Baccalaureate. (2018). *Primary Years Programme: From principles into practice, Transdisciplinary learning*. International Baccalaureate Organization.

# Arts: Subject overview

## Introduction

The purpose of this section is to provide an overview of the subject of arts in the PYP.

There are several aspects to consider in arts and learning in the PYP. These are addressed through focused guidance sections which can be read along with teacher support materials and tools that help scaffold the PYP in practice. These include the following publications:

- *Subject continuums: Arts*
- *Subject continuums: Personal, social and physical education*
- *Inquiry learning progressions*
- *Primary Years Programme: From principles into practice* > **“The early learner”**

# Arts

Arts play a vital role in schools, fostering creativity, curiosity, and critical thinking. By encouraging learners to think like artists, we develop individuals who seek answers, explore ideas, and express themselves (Foley, 2014). Through self-expression and **multimodal** communication, art enables learners to explore individuality and connectedness.

Engaging with, responding to, or creating **artworks**, prompts learners to reconsider familiar concepts, think critically about culture and identity. These artworks provide opportunities to engage with, critically reflect on, and express diverse historical, social, and cultural perspectives, and consider other possibilities. Arts are fundamental to a holistic education, supporting the development of transdisciplinary skills and personal well-being.

The PYP recognizes that arts bring unique opportunities for learning, communication and expression. Learning about, and through, the arts is fundamental to the development of the whole child, promoting creativity, critical thinking, problem-solving skills, and social interactions.

## Arts in the PYP

In the PYP, arts are identified as **dance**, **drama**, **music** and **visual arts**. Each of these arts is a significant discipline in its own right, but their transdisciplinary nature gives them relevance throughout the curriculum.

- **Dance** plays a vital role in society, bringing people and communities together. As an art form, dance explores self-expression through movement. The physical nature of dance creates a strong link with the movement strand in the personal, social and physical education subject learning continuum.
  - To learn more about this, refer to [Subject continuums: Personal, social and physical education](#)
- **Drama** explores self-expression through physical and vocal means, using facial expressions, gestures, movement, posture, and vocal **techniques** to convey emotional or cultural meaning.
- Exploration in **music** enables learners to communicate in unique ways, beyond their oral language abilities. As a part of everyday life, music plays a significant role in society, bringing people and communities together.
- **Visual arts** are an integral part of everyday life, supporting exploration of ways to make and create meaning in response to the diverse messages in the world around us.

For more information on the four arts disciplines, refer to the [Subject continuums: Arts](#)

Arts in the PYP exemplify learning through inquiry due to of the emphasis on, and the nature of, the creative **process**. Through arts, students engage with concepts and build understandings of the world around them. "Works of art provoke rich, multi-layered meaning making in ways unlike other disciplines. They raise questions, evoke connection-making, and in many ways, transform the shape of inquiry" (Tishman, Palmer, 2006).

Moreover, arts foster innovative thinking and creative use of technologies, encouraging students to explore uses of media tools beyond their basic functions. This prepares students to participate fully in a multimodal world.

## Arts and transdisciplinary learning

Arts provide a unique vehicle to support transdisciplinary learning, providing both students and educators a range of mediums to access and enhance units of inquiry. Arts support the acquisition of essential

knowledge and skills, the development of conceptual understanding, the demonstration of the IB learner profile, and the taking of action.

The school's programme of inquiry provides a relevant and authentic context for students to engage with, create, and respond to arts. Wherever possible, arts are taught through the units of inquiry and support students' curiosities. It is recognized that, at times, there may be a need for units which are planned separately, but which connect through, for example, concepts, a line of inquiry or the IB learner profile. Units are planned based on the interests and emerging theories of learners and the units support learners in making connections between the different aspects of their learning.

The arts component of the curriculum also provides opportunities for students to:

- explore and develop subject-specific knowledge, skills, and conceptual understandings
- develop the skills necessary to create, perform and discuss art
- express feelings, ideas, experiences, and beliefs in a variety of ways
- enjoy engaging with arts as both creators and audience members
- evaluate the different roles of artists in society, such as to entertain, provoke debate, or challenge views and perceptions.

# Concepts

Concepts are fundamental, abstract ideas (often encapsulated in one word) which support the development of conceptual understanding. The PYP identifies seven specified concepts that facilitate planning for a conceptual approach to transdisciplinary and subject-specific learning. Alongside the specified concepts, other concepts are explored within and outside units of inquiry (*Primary Years Programme: From principles into practice > Learning and teaching > "Conceptual understanding in the PYP", 2025*).

## Specified concepts

Specified concepts are a key element of the PYP framework. They guide the planning of meaningful arts learning experiences intended to embrace learning and teaching through inquiry.

When explored as questions, these concepts enable purposeful and manageable inquiry. (*Primary Years Programme: From principles into practice > Learning and teaching > "Conceptual understanding in the PYP", 2025*) These questions, used flexibly by educators and students when planning an inquiry-based unit, shape that unit, giving it direction.

The following table explains each concept from the perspective of arts.

Table 1

*Specified concepts from the perspective of arts*

| Specified concept                       | Generic perspective                                                                                                                   | Arts perspective                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
|-----------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Form</b><br>What is it like?         | The understanding that everything has a form with recognizable features that can be observed, identified, described, and categorized. | A form of communication that allows us to convey ideas, feelings, and concepts to an audience through various mediums including visual art, music, words, movements, and expressions.                               |
| <b>Function</b><br>How does it work?    | The understanding that everything has a purpose, role, or a way of behaving that can be investigated.                                 | Creativity is used to convey messages that can be practical, educational, cultural, or personal. A relationship is developed between the artist and the audience, where informed opinions or choices may be made.   |
| <b>Causation</b><br>Why is it as it is? | The understanding that things do not just happen; there are causal relationships at work, and that actions have consequences.         | A creative, emotional, and thoughtful interpretation of the world, influenced by cultural and personal experiences.                                                                                                 |
| <b>Change</b><br>How is it changing?    | The understanding that change is the process of movement from one state to another. It is universal and inevitable.                   | Arts are never static. As the world changes, the methods and means of the arts must also evolve. Experiences in the arts will alter according to the individual interpretations of the participant or the audience. |



| Specified concept                                      | Generic perspective                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       | Arts perspective                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
|--------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Connection</b><br>How is it linked to other things? | The understanding that we live in a world of interacting systems in which the actions of any individual element affect others.                                                                                                                                                                            | A universal language enabling communication within and across cultures and time periods.                                                                                                                                                  |
| <b>Perspective</b><br>What are the points of view?     | The understanding that knowledge is not neutral, is incomplete, and is socially and contextually constructed; it can be moderated by different points of view which lead to different interpretations, understandings, and findings; perspectives may be individual, group, cultural or subject-specific. | Arts offer the opportunity for creative choice, allowing different perspectives to emerge depending on one's role: creating or composing, performing or displaying, viewing or listening.                                                 |
| <b>Responsibility</b><br>What are our obligations?     | The understanding that people make choices based on their understandings, beliefs and values and actions they take have intended and unintended impacts and consequences.                                                                                                                                 | Conveys a powerful message to an audience, and we must be aware that our interpretations can affect others. We must also take an active role in preserving the arts and promote awareness and appreciation of arts from diverse cultures. |

## Examples of questions that illustrate the specified concepts

The following table provides example arts questions that illustrate the specified concepts, which may help structure or frame an inquiry. These examples demonstrate broad, open-ended questioning—requiring investigation, discussion, and a full and considered response—that is essential in an inquiry-based programme.

Table 2

### Example questions illustrating the specified concepts in arts

| Specified concept                    | Example questions                                                                                                                     |                                                                                                                           |                                                                                                                                  |                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
|--------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|                                      | Dance                                                                                                                                 | Drama                                                                                                                     | Music                                                                                                                            | Visual arts                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| <b>Form</b><br>What is it like?      | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>What makes this dance unique?</li> <li>What is the story in this dance performance?</li> </ul> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>What was the performance about?</li> <li>How might this character move?</li> </ul> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>What makes a song a folk song?</li> <li>What sounds do you hear in this music?</li> </ul> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Why have you chosen this material or tool?</li> <li>What <b>elements</b> did the artist focus on in this piece and how has it shaped the meaning?</li> </ul> |
| <b>Function</b><br>How does it work? | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>How might you move in response to this music?</li> </ul>                                       | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>In what different ways might a character</li> </ul>                                | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>What sounds can you make with this instrument?</li> </ul>                                 | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>How can you show yourself feeling angry/sad/happy/frightened?</li> </ul>                                                                                     |

| Specified concept                                      | Example questions                                                                                                                                                                                  |                                                                                                                                                                                                       |                                                                                                                                                                                               |                                                                                                                                                         |
|--------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|                                                        | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>How might you show your feelings through movement?</li> </ul>                                                                                               | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>express emotion?</li> <li>How can you create the sounds of the beach using your voice?</li> </ul>                                                              | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>In what way do these musical signs or symbols help us understand how to play this song?</li> </ul>                                                     | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>How is colour used in advertising?</li> </ul>                                                                    |
| <b>Causation</b><br>Why is it as it is?                | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>What is the relationship between the beginning and the ending of this dance performance?</li> <li>How does the environment impact on your dance?</li> </ul> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Why did the characters behave in this way?</li> <li>Who was your favourite character and why?</li> </ul>                                                       | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Why is a steady beat important in an ensemble performance?</li> <li>How has the culture and context of the composer influenced their music?</li> </ul> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Why do you think this piece of art has been made?</li> <li>What do you think influenced the artist?</li> </ul>   |
| <b>Change</b><br>How is it changing?                   | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>What differences did you notice between the rehearsal and the final dance performance?</li> <li>How can you utilize space when improvising?</li> </ul>      | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>How can constructive criticism improve your performance?</li> <li>How might setting the story in another context impact the way the story develops?</li> </ul> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>What would happen to a song if the tempo went from allegro to largo?</li> <li>What impact has technology had on the composition of music?</li> </ul>   | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>In what ways has fashion changed over time?</li> <li>How has new media influenced artistic practices?</li> </ul> |
| <b>Connection</b><br>How is it linked to other things? | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>What links are there between cultural practices and dance?</li> <li>How will you use peer feedback to improve your performance?</li> </ul>                  | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>How is watching a live show similar to or different from watching television?</li> <li>How can we find out about our past through stories?</li> </ul>          | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>How does the instrument's size relate to its pitch?</li> <li>In what types of celebrations would you hear this music?</li> </ul>                       | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>How does art help us celebrate?</li> <li>How do our experiences impact how we connect with artworks?</li> </ul>  |
| <b>Perspective</b><br>What are the points of view?     | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>How did you feel after watching a ballet?</li> <li>Which movements</li> </ul>                                                                               | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Which character did you identify with, and why?</li> <li>How do you think that</li> </ul>                                                                      | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Which instruments would you choose to play this pattern or song, and why?</li> </ul>                                                                   | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>How does art include or exclude people?</li> <li>How does someone's</li> </ul>                                   |

| Specified concept                                  | Example questions                                                                                                                                                                      |                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |                                                                                                                                                                        |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
|----------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|                                                    | are easier to learn?                                                                                                                                                                   | character is feeling now?                                                                                                                                                                                       | • How does this music make you feel?                                                                                                                                   | culture influence the work they produce?                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| <b>Responsibility</b><br>What are our obligations? | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• What do you need to do to prepare for this movement composition?</li> <li>• Which movements are safe for all members of the group?</li> </ul> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• In what ways can you help the group to complete the task?</li> <li>• How does your interpretation of the character reflect the intention of the playwright?</li> </ul> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• What can each musician in a group do to make a good performance?</li> <li>• How can we look after this instrument?</li> </ul> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Who do you need to speak to and involve in this project, and why?</li> <li>• What responsibility does an artist have to include diverse and divergent perspectives in their work?</li> </ul> |

## Other concepts

The specified concepts for arts are supported by additional concepts selected in response to the unit's goals and the needs and interests of learners. Examples include concepts, such as interpretation, performance, imagination, symbols, culture and techniques.

For further examples of concepts that can be explored through arts, as well as subject-specific concepts, refer to the [Subject continuums: Arts](#).

## The arts learner

The arts learner reflects and responds to events and experiences around them in ways that can entertain, engage, inform, challenge, and provoke. Arts provide opportunities for students to inquire into the world around them. Through personal and shared inquiries, they investigate the past, the present, and consider future possibilities. Through their inquiries, they develop skills such as observation, investigation, questioning, collaboration, creative and critical thinking, and reflection. Arts are a way of conveying meaning, sharing a culture, developing one's sense of self, and expanding knowledge.

As artists they:

- engage with, respond to, and create art works and performances
- investigate connections between their lives and the art works and performances of others
- build a toolkit of skills and techniques to shape their own work
- closely observe and question the context within which art works and performances are created, asking whose stories are, and are not, being told
- work individually and collectively, to make choices.

The PYP develops learners who are curious inquirers with the skills, knowledge and conceptual understandings that they need to be engaged and active lifelong learners.

## Agency and the arts learner

Learner agency is rooted in the principle that learners have the ability and the will to positively influence their own lives and the world around them. Exercising their agency, arts learners take ownership of their

learning, express their ideas and opinions, and reflect on their development of the IB learner profile attributes.

Learners strive to make sense of their lives and the world around them by constructing meaning, exploring concepts, revising understanding and directing their learning as they respond to and create art works and performances. The culminating exhibition in the final year of the PYP provides an opportunity to practise and demonstrate student agency, and the IB learner profile attributes.

## Action and the arts learner

As an artist, learners can use their understanding of the powerful messages they respond to and create to take individual or collective action, challenging thinking, bringing hidden stories into the light and provoking reflection.

Table 3

*Demonstrations of action in arts*

| Action                  | Arts examples could include                                                                                                                                           |
|-------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Participation           | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Inviting community members into school to enjoy a musical performance or taking the performance into the community.</li> </ul> |
| Advocacy                | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Creating posters or graphics to inform the community about an issue of importance to the learners.</li> </ul>                  |
| Social justice          | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Exploring the lived experiences of different characters in a story.</li> </ul>                                                 |
| Social entrepreneurship | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Running an art club or dance group for interested peers.</li> </ul>                                                            |
| Lifestyle choices       | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Creating a photo or video exhibition to highlight an environmental issue which impacts their community.</li> </ul>             |

## The early arts learner

As a form of **symbolic language**, arts allow early learners to discover and explore the world around them and construct meaning. Loris Malaguzzi speaks of the 100 languages of children (Edwards et al., 2012) and the endless possibilities they offer for learners to express themselves. He also cautions us that these languages should not be taken away but supported and allowed to flourish.

Within a collaborative and supportive setting, young learners are capable of sustained and deliberate exploration of the different arts forms, using these symbolic languages to explore, examine, question, predict, share, investigate, and reflect. Educators observe and listen carefully to discover, reflect on, and grow learners' understanding and use of these symbolic languages. Learners should experience arts through playful exploration and guided activities, supported by the thoughtful provision of materials, artefacts, provocations, and invitations.

To learn more about the early learner, refer to [Primary Years Programme: From principles into practice](#) > “The early learner”

## The arts educator

In many schools, single-subject educators take responsibility for the different arts areas. However, it is vital that these educators see themselves primarily as PYP educators who teach arts, contributing to the overall outcomes of a transdisciplinary programme.

The following examples of practice may serve as a guide, but the list is not exhaustive and may be added to according to the context of your school.

- Collaborate with classroom educators and other single-subject educators, to plan and develop central ideas, incorporating their input. This could include an arts-led unit of inquiry, supported by classroom educators and other single-subject educators

- Consider that students learn, observe, and perform in different areas of the school and community
- Use arts as an avenue to inquiry and develop inquiry skills, such as observation, questioning, and investigation
- Incorporate a variety of modalities, activities, assessments, and artistic experiences
- Share art works and performances from diverse contexts, cultures, genres, time periods, and languages
- Use learners' questions, interests, and curiosities to guide arts projects
- Encourage and value individual and collective creativity
- Assess learners' understanding regularly throughout all stages of the creative process, as well as the final product.

## Arts in the learning community

Every school community is unique, welcoming and inclusive, providing a space where learners and their families see themselves, their language, and culture reflected; feel safe, valued, and a sense of belonging.

Relationships are built with learners, staff, parents, guardians, and the wider community. These relationships, within the school's inclusive and safe environment, foster a positive arts culture, exploring diverse perspectives and supporting the development of international-mindedness. To develop these relationships, educators and learners are encouraged engage with the community and invite them into the school.

The following table illustrates how arts can play a role at all levels of the learning community. These examples are not exhaustive and can be adapted and added to within your own context.

*Table 4*  
**Arts in the learning community**

| Arts in the learning community                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Reaching out to the community                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               | Inviting the community in                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| <b>Classroom</b> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Participate in a peer's dance or role-play</li> <li>• Provide feedback to a peer during, or after a creative process</li> </ul>                                                                                   | <b>Classroom</b> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Share personal experiences from home that represent cultural and linguistic diversity, such as artefacts and music</li> <li>• Ensure diversity in the provided materials, artefacts, and tools</li> </ul> |
| <b>School</b> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Share performances in assemblies or create an art gallery in a shared space</li> <li>• Foster peer mentoring or tutoring to share knowledge and skills, for example, teach younger learners put on a play</li> </ul> | <b>School</b> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Invite other classes in for a gallery walk or to watch a performance and to give feedback</li> <li>• Find out what artistic talents people in the school have and use them to support learners</li> </ul>    |
| <b>The wider community</b> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Sing in a supported living facility or contribute to an arts-based community project</li> <li>• Organize trips to museums, theatres, or orchestras</li> </ul>                                           | <b>The wider community</b> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Invite guest speakers from the arts community to the school</li> <li>• Engage with arts-related issues in the news or on social media</li> </ul>                                                |

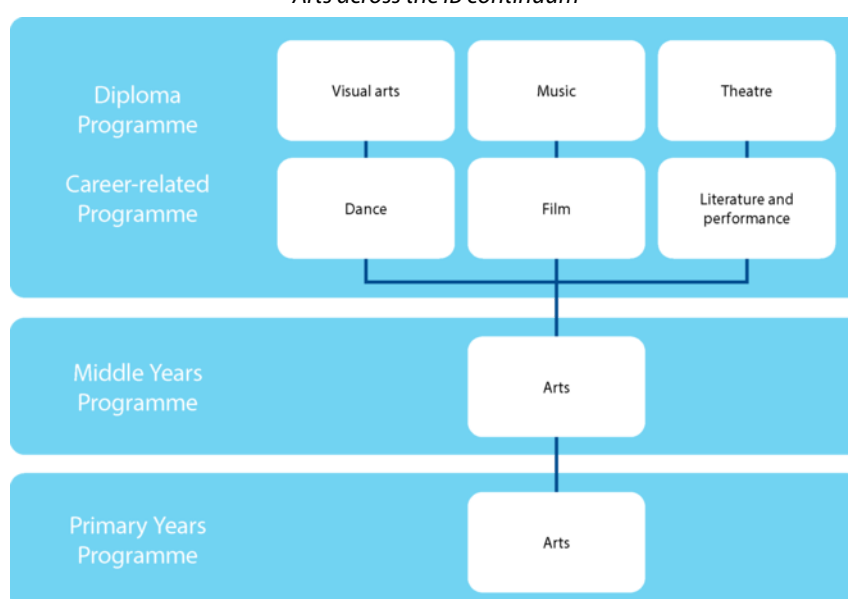
## Arts across the IB continuum

The IB's programmes provide a continuum of learning for learners aged 3–19. In the PYP, learning in arts provides opportunities for learners to engage with and respond to art works and performances of others as well as opportunities to express themselves through their own creative processes.

Through all these opportunities learners find enjoyment in arts they experience and create. In turn, they build a foundation of knowledge, skills, and conceptual understandings that can be further developed in the Middle Years Programme (MYP). The Diploma Programme (DP) and Career-related Programme (CP) offer learners the opportunity to focus on one area of arts and to develop specialized knowledge, skills, and understandings within that subject.

Figure 2

Arts across the IB continuum



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# Language: Subject overview

## Introduction

The purpose of this section is to provide an overview of the subject of language, including additional language(s), in the PYP.

There are several aspects to consider in language and learning in the PYP. These are addressed through focused guidance sections which can be read along with teacher support materials and tools that help scaffold the PYP in practice. These include the following publications:

- *Subject continuums: Language*
- *Inquiry learning progressions*
- *IB language tenets*
- Additional language(s) resources
- *Primary Years Programme: From principles into practice > Learning and teaching > “Language”*
- *Primary Years Programme: From principles into practice > The learner > “The early learner” > “Symbolic exploration and expression”*



# Language

Language is a social practice, “a product of the deeply social and cultural activities in which people engage” (Pennycook, 2010). Meaning-making occurs through interactions with other people and the world. Meaning is not stored in the head but constructed in the here and now in response to the context in which we find ourselves (Gee, 2004). For learning and teaching in primary education, this means being concerned about language curriculum content and skills, as well as social contexts and identity. It also means supporting students in participating in their local and global contexts, and the roles these play now and in students’ futures.

Language plays a pivotal role in shaping the learner’s educational journey. Early communication, self-expression and interaction with symbolic language form the foundations of language and literacy. These contribute to the learner’s growing **linguistic repertoire**. Language is the vehicle for learning and thinking across and through all subjects as learners ask questions, explore ideas, and construct their understandings in collaborative contexts.

In a multilingual world, students engage responsively with languages and cultures both locally and globally to support the development of intercultural understanding.

## Language in the PYP

Language in the PYP is grounded in the belief that language is a social practice, essential for transdisciplinary inquiry learning and identity construction. Learning and teaching start with the learner’s and their needs, interests, and experiences, making their unique language repertoires central to the learning process. This extends beyond the subject of language, enabling learners to make sense and meaning of all learning within and across subjects.

In learning experiences, language is used to collaborate and to create meaning through various modes in the form of **text**, including print, visual, linguistic, spatial, and gestural. Text can express meaning in single modes or by combining modes to create text. For example, digital texts combine images and words, as do performances and film, even storybooks combine visual and print modes.

Multiliteracy is the combination of both multilingualism and multimodality. In the PYP, educators support the development of multiliteracy by providing opportunities for learners to inquire into and develop skills in the ways in which language is used to make meaning beyond the written word.

Language in the PYP encompasses several interrelated aspects, including:

- language as a subject (discipline)
- language across and between the subjects (transdisciplinary)
- literacy
- additional language(s)
- home and family languages
- multiliteracies
- communication.

For more information on the four strands, refer to “[Subject continuums: Language](#)”

### Language as a subject

Within the PYP, skills, knowledge, and understandings specific to the subject of the language are explored and developed. This includes language across the subjects and the learning of additional languages.

To support the design of language learning and teaching, the PYP provides a set of subject continuums that organize language into four strands. These are **oral language—listening and speaking**, **visual language—viewing and presenting**, **written language—reading** and **written language—writing**.

Resources are also provided to support additional language learning, guiding educators through aspects of language learning in the areas of **interaction**, **culture and identity**, and **text construction**.

In the PYP, language learners inquire into text in personal, local, and global multilingual contexts to:

- develop skills in creating and communicating text in various modes such as print, visual, oral, and multilingual
- take pleasure in the emotions that can be communicated through text, such as empathy, beauty, humour and joy
- develop critical, reflective, creative, and personal approaches to interpreting and constructing text
- appreciate multiple and divergent perspectives through texts from different places, times and cultures
- apply and reflect on linguistic and literary concepts and skills in a variety of authentic contexts
- recognize the differences and similarities in language across subjects and navigate their structures and features.

## Language and transdisciplinary learning

Language sits at the heart of transdisciplinary learning. As in the disciplines, subjects “overlap, inform, and intersect with one another” (Byrd Clark, 2016). Inquiry-based learning through the PYP transdisciplinary themes offers opportunities to explore and develop language by following learners’ curiosity to observe, question, wonder, and share thoughts. Within a multilingual learning community, collaboration provides further avenues for language use and growth as learners encounter new ideas, reflect critically on their learning, and develop their linguistic identity in a supportive, enriching environment.

By design, units of inquiry provide authentic opportunities to inquire into language and to inquire through language, in both language and additional language(s). Knowledge and skills are developed through a collaborative, reflective process that focuses on conceptual understanding.

# Concepts

Concepts are fundamental, abstract ideas (often encapsulated in one word) that support the development of conceptual understanding. The PYP identifies seven specified concepts that facilitate planning for a conceptual approach to transdisciplinary and subject-specific learning. Alongside these specified concepts, other concepts are explored within and outside units of inquiry (*Primary Years Programme: From principles into practice > Learning and teaching > “Conceptual understanding in the PYP”, 2025*).

## Specified concepts

Specified concepts are a key element of the PYP framework. They guide the planning of meaningful language learning experiences intended to embrace learning and teaching through inquiry.

When explored as questions, these concepts enable purposeful and manageable inquiry (*Primary Years Programme: From principles into practice > Learning and teaching > “Conceptual understanding in the PYP”, 2025*). These questions, used flexibly by educators and students when planning an inquiry-based unit, shape that unit, giving it direction.

The following table explains each concept from the perspective of language.

Table 5  
*Specified concepts from the perspective of language*

| Specified concept                                      | Generic perspective                                                                                                                   | Language perspective                                                                                                   |
|--------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Form</b><br>What is it like?                        | The understanding that everything has a form with recognizable features that can be observed, identified, described, and categorized. | Languages, and their variants, are systems with identifiable parts.<br>Language can have multimodal elements.          |
| <b>Function</b><br>How does it work?                   | The understanding that everything has a purpose, a role or a way of behaving that can be investigated.                                | The type of language used varies depending on the circumstances, purpose, audience, and genre.                         |
| <b>Causation</b><br>Why is it as it is?                | The understanding that things do not just happen; there are causal relationships at work, and that actions have consequences.         | Language is fundamental to human activity. Many factors influence the development of languages and language variation. |
| <b>Change</b><br>How is it changing?                   | The understanding that change is the process of movement from one state to another. It is universal and inevitable.                   | Language is not static; it evolves over time and in relation to context and tools.                                     |
| <b>Connection</b><br>How is it linked to other things? | The understanding that we live in a world of interacting systems in which the actions of any individual element affect others.        | Language serves as a major connecting system within, between, and among all communities.                               |
| <b>Perspective</b><br>What are the points of view?     | The understanding that knowledge is not neutral, is incomplete, and is socially and                                                   | Language can be interpreted and expressed in diverse ways. Languages offer valuable insights into                      |

| Specified concept                                  | Generic perspective                                                                                                                                                                                                   | Language perspective                                                                                                                                                                               |
|----------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|                                                    | contextually constructed; it can be moderated by different points of view which lead to different interpretations, understandings and findings; perspectives may be individual, group, cultural, or subject-specific. | experiences and other cultures, fostering understanding and connection.                                                                                                                            |
| <b>Responsibility</b><br>What are our obligations? | The understanding that people make choices based on their understandings, beliefs and values, and the actions they take have intended and unintended impacts and consequences.                                        | Language is powerful and can have a profound impact, both positively and negatively. As such, it should be used responsibly, with consideration for its effects on others and the world around us. |

## Examples of questions that illustrate the specified concepts

The following table provides examples of language questions that illustrate the specified concepts, which may help structure or frame an inquiry. These examples demonstrate broad, open-ended questioning—requiring investigation, discussion, and a full and considered response—that is essential in an inquiry-based programme.

Table 6

### Example questions illustrating specified concepts in language

| Specified concept                                      | Example questions                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
|--------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Form</b><br>What is it like?                        | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• What are the ways in which stories can be shared?</li> <li>• What are the parts of a text?</li> <li>• What languages do the students in our class/school use?</li> <li>• What is distinct about this language?</li> </ul>                                              |
| <b>Function</b><br>How does it work?                   | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• What part does literature or storytelling play in the development of a culture?</li> <li>• Why do we name things?</li> <li>• How do different languages work?</li> <li>• How do pictures and writing work together?</li> </ul>                                         |
| <b>Causation</b><br>Why is it as it is?                | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• What part does language play in culture and identity?</li> <li>• To what extent does language influence thinking?</li> <li>• Why does the same language develop differently in different places?</li> <li>• Why did the author create the text in this way?</li> </ul> |
| <b>Change</b><br>How is it changing?                   | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• How have our languages changed over time?</li> <li>• What has influenced the development of specific language modes?</li> <li>• How do we use language differently as we grow?</li> <li>• How have other languages and cultures changed our own language?</li> </ul>   |
| <b>Connection</b><br>How is it linked to other things? | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• What are the similarities and differences between languages?</li> <li>• How is language used in different subjects?</li> <li>• How are storytelling traditions linked to culture?</li> <li>• How do our experiences enable us to connect with stories?</li> </ul>      |

| Specified concept                                  | Example questions                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
|----------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Perspective</b><br>What are the points of view? | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• How could knowledge of a language help us to understand culture?</li> <li>• Why do some books become bestsellers?</li> <li>• How does language include or exclude people?</li> <li>• Why is written language different to spoken language?</li> </ul>                                       |
| <b>Responsibility</b><br>What are our obligations? | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• How can the use of language influence people?</li> <li>• How should we treat people who speak different languages from us?</li> <li>• Why are we not allowed to read some books or websites?</li> <li>• What responsibility does the author have to avoid bias and stereotyping?</li> </ul> |

## Other concepts

The specified concepts for language are supported by additional concepts selected in response to the unit's goals and the needs and interests of learners. Examples include concepts such as **literacy, pattern, perspective, symbol, tone, and voice**.

For further examples of concepts that can be explored through language, as well as other subject-specific concepts, refer to the [Subject continuums: Language](#).

## The language learner

PYP learners bring a unique set of personal experiences, characteristics, and skills to the learning community, infusing multilingual classrooms with rich diversity. Some learners are new to the school's language(s), and schools support all students by inquiring into and valuing their language repertoires. This enables learners to access and share their home and family languages, exercising agency through pedagogical **translanguaging** approaches. Recognizing that prior language knowledge is central to cognitive development, schools support language development by making provision for all languages. Learners are not asked to replace their existing language(s) with new ones but to expand their language repertoire, exercising agency as they do so.

Language is fundamental to the development and demonstration of the attributes of the IB learner profile and to international-mindedness. PYP students, as inquirers, thinkers, and communicators, recognize that meaning-making can occur through various languages, dialects, and socio-cultural contexts, in both verbal and non-verbal ways.

### Agency and the language learner

Language plays a vital role in learner agency, serving as a means of expressing and reflecting on agency and co-agency, as well as facilitating aspects of learning, such as the co-construction of learning goals and inquiries. Collaborative language use enhances agency enabling students to take ownership of their learning, develop their voice, and take action. Relationships, personal perspectives, choices, needs, and ideas all contribute to this process. The culminating exhibition in the final year of the PYP provides an opportunity to practise and demonstrate student agency, and the IB learner profile attributes.

### Action and the language learner

Learners demonstrate agency by taking action through their language choices and using their language to reflect on their actions. This becomes evident through goal setting and in collaborating with others in school and across the learning community.

*Table 7*  
***Demonstrations of action in language***

| Action                  | Language examples could include the following.                                                                                                                                 |
|-------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Participation           | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Encourage peers new to the school's language(s) to take on roles in collaborative tasks.</li> </ul>                                     |
| Advocacy                | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Create posters with persuasive text or participate in debates to inform the community about issues of personal significance.</li> </ul> |
| Social justice          | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Support peers new to the school's language(s) by creating opportunities to share cultural or linguistic knowledge.</li> </ul>           |
| Social entrepreneurship | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Run a poetry club or literary magazine or translate in a local language context.</li> </ul>                                             |
| Lifestyle choices       | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Decide to learn a new language or find ways to interact in new contexts using a language they are learning.</li> </ul>                  |

## The early language learner

Early language learning occurs through interactions with others, and young learners bring their distinct curiosities, knowledge, skills and understandings of the world to school. In the PYP, educators support transdisciplinary learning with young learners through four interwoven elements:

- planning uninterrupted time for play
- building strong relationships with students and their families
- creating and maintaining responsive spaces for play
- offering many opportunities for symbolic exploration and expression.

Language is a social practice, and school offers a wealth of new language experiences for the young learner as they negotiate relationships, navigate the learning environment, and encounter new literacy experiences. At this age, learners are bursting with curiosity about the world, and their vocabulary expands rapidly as they explore their learning environment through play. Educators support the development of symbolic exploration and expression by listening carefully to learners' language, discovering and reflecting on their mental language models through targeted support.

To learn more about the early learner, refer to [Primary Years Programme: From principles into practice > The learner > "The early learner"](#).

## The literate language learner

PYP students come from a rich, diverse world of languages, most of which have a written form, although some, like sign language and certain local and indigenous languages, do not. Writing systems or scripts consist of symbols, such as letters or graphics used to communicate meaning. These symbols vary across languages like Arabic, Greek, or Spanish, Chinese, Japanese, and Korean.

PYP schools support learners in becoming literate in multiple languages, enabling them to understand and use various modes of print, visual, or gestural language appropriate to the social context. Literacy skills are closely tied to oral language development.

Learning through, within, and across the subjects requires understanding how each subject constructs and conveys meaning. Subjects reflect the wider discipline-specific structures, features, vocabulary, and ways of building knowledge. This is evident when comparing the language features found, for example, in a play or a science report.

Literacy in schools is a multifaceted, culturally embedded notion that includes understandings and skills that:

- involve learning through language and learning about language
- support making and creating meaning by engaging with, and constructing text

- are socio-cultural and contextual in nature
- can be subject-related
- are developed through multiliteracies and encompass multilingual learning
- are designed to support learners to be effective communicators
- are approached in a spirit of inquiry.

The example subject continuum for language support literacy learning and teaching for all PYP school languages, providing a coherent set of outcomes across four phases. However, they do not offer tailored details for literacy learning specific to each language. Instead, schools identify and utilize appropriate resources to support their unique language profile.

## The language educator

All IB educators recognize their role as teachers of language and in nurturing student language repertoires within IB programmes. Language educators are themselves reflective inquirers, learning about their students' unique experiences and interests, their language goals, knowledge, skills and understandings to personalize learning.

Single-subject and homeroom educators collaborate to share insights and ideas in support of their learners' language development and monitor and document this. Educators and learners co-construct language learning goals, and opportunities are provided for students to share their languages and linguistic identity with others.

In designing units of inquiry and learning experiences, educators have the agency to ensure their planning is responsive to the language needs of learners. They design learning experiences with an awareness of how barriers to learning can occur through language, and they work collaboratively to address these barriers. They advocate for learners' language repertoires as a right and value them as a resource or strength. Through collaboration with others within and beyond the learning community, educators develop their knowledge of languages and language learning for all their learners.

Educators model, develop, and demonstrate the language of the subjects, supporting learners in making language connections within and between the subjects and across the programme of inquiry. They develop their learners' language of inquiry by providing engaging collaborative experiences to support them to:

- explore and discover
- question
- participate and interact
- represent and share
- investigate
- make decisions
- critically reflect
- take action.

## Language in the learning community

Every school community is unique, welcoming and inclusive, providing a space where learners and their families see themselves, their language, and culture reflected; feel safe, valued, and a sense of belonging.

Relationships are built with learners, staff, parents, legal guardians, and the wider community. To develop these relationships, educators and learners are encouraged to engage with the community and invite them into the school.

These relationships, within the school's inclusive and safe environment, offer many opportunities to build a positive, internationally-minded culture through language experiences.

The following table illustrates how language can play a role at all levels of the learning community. These examples are not exhaustive and can be adapted and added to within your own context.

Table 8  
*Language in the learning community*

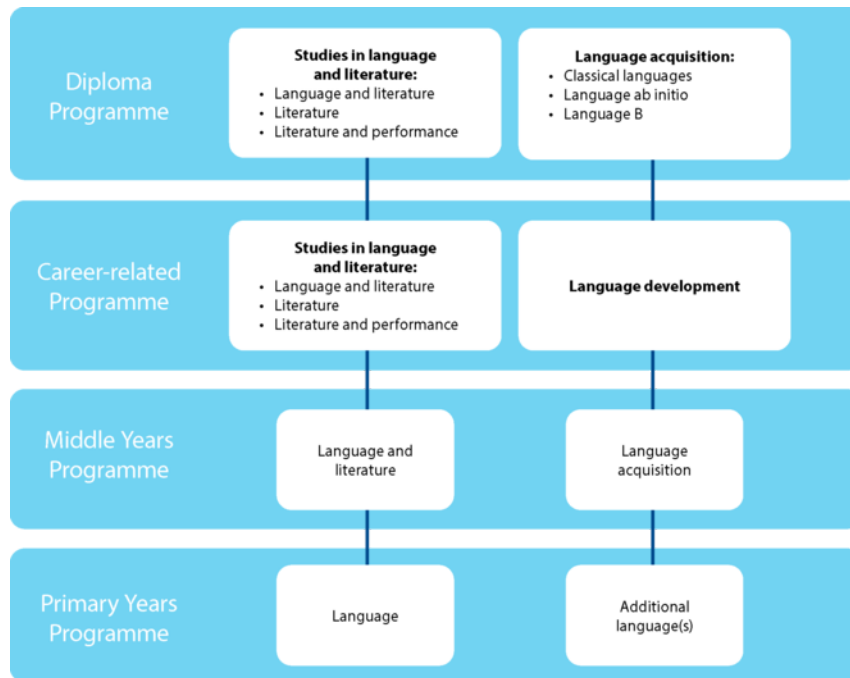
| Language in the learning community                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Reaching out to the community                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  | Inviting the community in                                                                                                                                                                            |
| <b>Classroom</b> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Share a book, poem, or story</li> <li>• Give feedback to a peer during, or after a collaborative activity</li> </ul>                                                                                                                 | <b>Classroom</b> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Discover artifacts in other languages</li> <li>• Conduct a survey of the class library for culturally responsive texts</li> </ul>          |
| <b>School</b> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Share performances in assemblies or create a shared space for stories or poetry</li> <li>• Foster peer mentoring or tutoring to share knowledge and skills, for example, help a group of younger students with reading texts</li> </ul> | <b>School</b> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Bring classes together to share favourite texts</li> <li>• Bring students together who share the same language</li> </ul>                     |
| <b>The wider community</b> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Build relationships with students from other schools or clubs</li> <li>• Use social media to share ideas</li> </ul>                                                                                                        | <b>The wider community</b> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Invite guest speakers or performers from the community to the school</li> <li>• Engage with issues in the local media</li> </ul> |

## Language across the IB continuum

Across the IB continuum, the central role of language in meaning-making and the development of students' language repertoires continues to be valued. There are opportunities to continue developing these through language subjects in the MYP, DP and CP.



Figure 3  
Language across the IB continuum



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## Additional language(s) resources

### Overview

These resources are designed by IB educators to support IB additional language(s) educators in their exploration of the additional language(s) learner pathway within IB schools.

Educators can select the resources that resonate and adapt them to suit their unique school context.

### Resources

#### Additional language(s) learner pathway

This resource is for IB additional language(s) educators, who wish to design and map language learning in their schools. It can be used to assess the language proficiency of learners and plan engaging learning experiences strategically. Serving as both a pathway and a map, this tool is designed to visually represent the developmental journey of additional language(s) learners through various stages of the three language-learning aspects: interaction; culture and identity; and constructing text. It has been designed to work with the outcomes and conceptual understandings from the *Subject continuums: Language*. The tool also supports the *IB language tenets* and can be used by schools to explore multilingual learning.

[Learner pathway \(PDF\)](#)

#### At a glance: The additional language(s) learner pathway

This resource provides a quick overview and explains how the additional language(s) learner pathway aids the planning and assessment of additional language(s) learners across a variety of school contexts. It provides clarity on the nature of the pathway, detailing its purpose and identifying potential users. Furthermore, the resource offers some quick suggestions for educators on leveraging the pathway effectively in their teaching practices.

[At a glance: The additional language\(s\) learner pathway \(PDF\)](#)

#### Practical ways of using and engaging with the additional language(s) learner pathway

This resource provides insights into multiple ways educators can effectively incorporate the additional language(s) learner pathway to enrich the learning and teaching experience of additional languages. It presents practical approaches for utilizing the pathway in planning, inspiring classroom learning and evaluating overall learning outcomes.

[Practical ways of using and engaging with the additional language\(s\) learner pathway \(PDF\)](#)

## A reflection tool for using the additional language(s) learner pathway

This infographic guides schools through a systematic process for developing and improving additional language(s) learning in their unique context. It offers schools some guidance in unpacking the pathway, evaluating their programme and discovering opportunities for enhancements within the pathway.

[A reflection tool for using the additional language\(s\) learner pathway \(PDF\)](#)

## PYP collaborative planning process for additional language(s)

An adapted version of the PYP collaborative planning process, this resource is crafted to offer additional language(s) educators a versatile planning resource that can be employed as is or tailored to align with diverse school contexts. The resource serves to guide educators in pinpointing a conceptual focus, establishing learning goals, identifying pertinent learning resources, implementing assessments and creating opportunities to bolster student agency. It aims to complement the additional language(s) learner pathway, allowing for the easy incorporation of pathway elements within the planning process.

[PYP collaborative planning process for additional language\(s\) \(PDF\)](#)

## Cards: Collaborative planning process for additional language(s) learning and teaching

This resource is designed to enhance the planning process for all PYP educators. It supports the PYP collaborative planning process but has been adapted for additional language(s) learning planning. The cards provide a flexible means of guiding collaborative planning conversations among language educators. The cards can be used to move through key elements of PYP learning while planning. They facilitate a targeted approach, ensuring that learners engage in concept-based learning while incorporating essential aspects of transdisciplinary learning, the approaches to learning, and fostering agency and action.

[Cards: Collaborative planning process for additional language\(s\) learning and teaching \(PDF\)](#)

## Other PYP resources

The following resources can be used to support additional language(s) learning and teaching. These are all available on the [Programme Resource Centre \(PRC\)](#).

International Baccalaureate. (2025). *Primary Years programme: From principles into practice, Learning and teaching*, "Language in the PYP". International Baccalaureate Organization.

International Baccalaureate. (2018). *How multilingual is my school—A self-audit tool*. International Baccalaureate Organization.

International Baccalaureate. (2018). *Student language agreements*. International Baccalaureate Organization.

International Baccalaureate. (2018). *Translanguaging*. International Baccalaureate Organization.

International Baccalaureate. (2019). *Student language portraits*. International Baccalaureate Organization.

International Baccalaureate. (2024). *IB language tenets*. International Baccalaureate Organization.

# Mathematics: Subject overview

## Introduction

The purpose of this section is to provide an overview of the subject of mathematics in the PYP.

There are several aspects to consider in mathematics and learning in the PYP. These are addressed through focused guidance sections which can be read along with teacher support materials and tools that help scaffold the PYP in practice. These include the following publications:

- *Subject continuums: Mathematics*
- *Inquiry learning progressions*
- *Primary Years Programme: From principles into practice* > *The learner* > **“The early learner”**

# Mathematics

Mathematics is viewed as a sense-making activity (Schoenfeld, 2019) that supports learners in understanding everyday situations and events. Learners are encouraged to consider mathematics as a way of thinking, rather than a series of disconnected facts and procedures to be memorized. By applying their understanding of mathematics concepts and skills, learners explore **authentic** situations as numerate individuals. Numeracy or mathematical literacy connects learners to their communities, enabling them to examine everyday situations by relying on their knowledge of mathematics concepts and skills to make informed decisions.

Ultimately, mathematics is a way of reasoning, making it essential for understanding concepts and ideas across, between and beyond subjects. Learners who reason mathematically look for and see mathematics in a variety of contexts. Furthermore, engaging in mathematical reasoning through cognitively demanding tasks promotes higher-order thinking (Felmer et al., 2016). In this way, mathematics provides a powerful framework for **problem-solving**, decision-making, creativity, critical thinking, and understanding the world.

## Mathematics in the PYP

Mathematics is integral to the PYP. It is a mode of reasoning through which learners explore, investigate, and make sense of mathematical ideas, developing a sense of self as confident and capable mathematicians. Learners are encouraged to consider their world through a mathematical lens as they develop an appreciation for the intrinsic beauty of mathematics. Learners value mathematical reasoning as they strive to use mathematics to make sense of the world and apply their understanding of mathematics concepts and skills to address personal and social issues. Through mathematics, learners develop a range of skills, including **computational thinking**, **mathematical modeling**, data analysis, and abstract reasoning.

Mathematics in the PYP includes five strands:

- data handling
- measurement
- shape and space
- pattern and function
- number.

For more information on the five strands, refer to the [Subject continuums: Mathematics](#)

Learners make connections between mathematics concepts and skills within each strand and across the strands. They enhance their understanding of mathematics concepts and skills through exploration and investigation. Learners construct meaning by reflecting on their experiences, understanding, and interactions with objects and others' ideas. Meaningful and relevant learning experiences include a range of open-ended, practical, hands-on problem-solving situations that provide all learners with an entry point to engage in mathematical thinking and discourse.

## Mathematics and transdisciplinary learning

Whenever possible, mathematics should be taught through the relevant, authentic context of the programme of inquiry. Exploring mathematics concepts through relevant and authentic contexts provides learners with opportunities to reflect on their development as young mathematicians and enhances their desire to engage with mathematics. Connections to the transdisciplinary themes should be explicitly made. A developing understanding of these connections contributes to the students' understanding of mathematics in the world and their understanding of the transdisciplinary theme. Developing reasoning,

including mathematical reasoning, further supports transdisciplinary learning, providing both students and educators with opportunities to make connections to the units of inquiry.

Teaching specific mathematics concepts and skills in a unit of inquiry may not always be feasible. Where appropriate, introductory or follow-up activities can help students make connections between mathematics skills and concepts and the unit of inquiry, as they engage in reasoning. Students also need opportunities to identify and reflect on key mathematical ideas within and between and across the different strands of mathematics, the programme of inquiry and other subjects. The role of inquiry in mathematics is crucial, regardless of whether it is being taught inside or outside the programme of inquiry.

# Concepts

Concepts are fundamental, abstract ideas (often encapsulated in one word) that support the development of conceptual understanding. The PYP identifies seven specified concepts that facilitate planning for a conceptual approach to transdisciplinary and subject-specific learning. Alongside these specified concepts, other concepts are explored within and outside units of inquiry (*Primary Years Programme: From principles into practice > Learning and teaching > “Conceptual understanding in the PYP”, 2025*).

## Specified concepts

Specified concepts are a key element of the PYP framework. They guide the planning of meaningful mathematical learning experiences intended to embrace learning and teaching through inquiry.

When explored as questions, these concepts enable purposeful and manageable inquiry (*Primary Years Programme: From principles into practice > Learning and teaching > “Conceptual understanding in the PYP”, 2025*). These questions, used flexibly by educators and students when planning an inquiry-based unit, shape that unit, giving it direction.

The following table explains each concept from the perspective of mathematics.

Table 9

*Specified concepts from the perspective of mathematics*

| Specified concept                                      | Generic perspective                                                                                                                   | Mathematics perspective                                                                                                                                                |
|--------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Form</b><br>What is it like?                        | The understanding that everything has a form with recognizable features that can be observed, identified, described, and categorized. | The recognition and description of patterns, sorting, comparing and contrasting, and generalizing.                                                                     |
| <b>Function</b><br>How does it work?                   | The understanding that everything has a purpose, a role or a way of behaving that can be investigated.                                | The examination of relationships, principles, properties, and patterns.                                                                                                |
| <b>Causation</b><br>Why is it as it is?                | The understanding that things do not just happen; there are causal relationships at work, and that actions have consequences.         | An examination of the mathematics concepts and processes that influence the way things are.                                                                            |
| <b>Change</b><br>How is it changing?                   | The understanding that change is the process of movement from one state to another. It is universal and inevitable.                   | Looking for evidence of change, analysing the evidence, drawing conclusions, and making predictions.                                                                   |
| <b>Connection</b><br>How is it linked to other things? | The understanding that we live in a world of interconnected systems in which the actions of any individual element affect others.     | The examination of strategies, properties, and principles to identify relationships, within and between different strands of mathematics and beyond to other subjects. |



| Specified concept                                  | Generic perspective                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            | Mathematics perspective                                                                                                                 |
|----------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Perspective</b><br>What are the points of view? | The understanding that knowledge is not neutral, is incomplete, and is socially and contextually constructed; it can be moderated by different points of view which lead to different interpretations, understandings and findings; these perspectives may be individual, group, cultural or subject-specific. | The examination of different ways individuals and cultures use mathematics to solve problems.                                           |
| <b>Responsibility</b><br>What are our obligations? | The understanding that people make choices based on their understandings, beliefs and values, and the actions they take have intended and unintended impacts and consequences.                                                                                                                                 | Understanding the importance of accurate communication and appreciating the obligation to apply mathematics with honesty and integrity. |

## Examples of questions that illustrate the specified concepts

The following table provides example mathematics questions that illustrate the specified concepts, which may help structure or frame an inquiry. These examples demonstrate broad, open-ended questioning—requiring investigation, discussion, and a full and considered response—that is essential in an inquiry-based programme.

Table 10

*Example questions illustrating the specified concepts in mathematics*

| Specified concept                       | Example questions                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
|-----------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Form</b><br>What is it like?         | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• What makes this a pattern?</li> <li>• How can we describe these shapes?</li> <li>• What is the sorting rule?</li> <li>• What strategy did you use?</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                                   |
| <b>Function</b><br>How does it work?    | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• What is the purpose of the scale on a graph?</li> <li>• What happens if we extend the pattern?</li> <li>• What makes this a composite shape?</li> <li>• How is multiplying like addition?</li> </ul>                                                                                                                            |
| <b>Causation</b><br>Why is it as it is? | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Why is a block the best shape for building a tower?</li> <li>• What is the purpose of the constant in a pattern rule?</li> <li>• What is the purpose of the multiplier in a pattern rule?</li> <li>• How does the place value system help us to compare numbers?</li> <li>• Why was the data displayed in this form?</li> </ul> |
| <b>Change</b><br>How is it changing?    | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• How can we convert from the 12-hour clock to the 24-hour clock?</li> <li>• How does changing the multiplier in a pattern rule affect the graph of the pattern?</li> <li>• How does changing the perimeter of a rectangle affect the area?</li> <li>• What happens when “0” is added to a number?</li> </ul>                     |
| <b>Connection</b>                       | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• How can you use fractions to explain musical notation?</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |

| Specified concept                                  | Example questions                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
|----------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| How is it linked to other things?                  | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• How are <math>4 + 3</math> and <math>3 + 4</math> connected?</li> <li>• How are the different representations of the pattern connected?</li> <li>• How can you use addition to help you subtract?</li> </ul>                                               |
| <b>Perspective</b><br>What are the points of view? | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• How else could you prove this?</li> <li>• Who might be interested in, or be able to use, the results of our survey?</li> <li>• What is the role of mathematics in different cultures?</li> <li>• What would make this game fair to all players?</li> </ul> |
| <b>Responsibility</b><br>What are our obligations? | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• What makes your answer reasonable?</li> <li>• Can you give an example of a biased graph? What makes it biased?</li> <li>• Why does the measurement need to be accurate?</li> <li>• How have you collected all the relevant data?</li> </ul>                |

## Other concepts

The specified concepts for mathematics are supported by additional concepts selected in response to the unit's goals and the needs and interests of learners. Examples include concepts such as **space, quantity, time, symbols, patterns** and **relationships**.

For further examples of concepts that can be explored through mathematics, as well as subject-specific concepts, refer to [Subject continuums: Mathematics](#).

## The mathematics learner

Integral to mathematics in the PYP is fostering creativity, critical thinking, and a sense of self-efficacy. Students are encouraged to rely on their mathematical intuition as they explore and make sense of mathematics concepts and skills in authentic contexts with willingness and perseverance. A learner demonstrates mathematical intuition when understand something without reasoning or rules (Tieszen, 2015). For example, many young learners who have not yet developed an understanding of capacity, still know instinctively, that a large pail will hold more water than a small pail.

The mathematics learner understands mathematics concepts and skills and is able to transfer and apply this understanding to make sense of the world around them.

As mathematicians, they:

- make sense of the mathematics concepts and skills
- pose mathematical wonderings
- interpret mathematical situations
- make conjectures
- make inferences
- provide reasonable estimates
- make informed decisions and sound judgements
- investigate collaboratively and independently
- express understanding of mathematics through multiple, varied models and representations
- select and use effective tools and strategies
- select and use mathematical skills effectively
- reflect on strategies, tools and methods
- engage in and communicate mathematical thinking
- justify reasoning

- critically interpret various forms of text.

## Agency and the mathematics learner

Learner agency is rooted in the principle that learners have the ability and the will to positively influence their own lives and the world around them. Exercising their agency, mathematics learners take ownership of their learning, express their ideas and opinions, and reflect on their development of the IB learner profile attributes.

Learners strive to make sense of their lives and the world around them by constructing meaning, exploring concepts, revising understanding, and directing their learning. Learners see themselves reflected in the curriculum, set goals, and use their mathematical knowledge and skills to make responsible decisions and take action. The culminating exhibition in the final year of the PYP provides an opportunity to practise and demonstrate student agency, and the IB learner profile attributes.

## Action and the mathematics learner

As young mathematicians, learners can use their understanding of mathematics to take individual or collective action. As curious, creative, and reflective community members, learners strive to make a difference to address authentic problems or make positive changes in the local or global community and provoke reflection.

Table 11

### *Demonstrations of action in mathematics*

| Action                  | Mathematics examples could include the following.                                                                                                    |
|-------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Participation           | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Inviting community members into school to enjoy a “mathematics night”.</li> </ul>                             |
| Advocacy                | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Creating posters or graphics to inform the community about an issue of importance to the learners.</li> </ul> |
| Social justice          | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Exploring issues of fairness from different mathematical perspectives.</li> </ul>                             |
| Social entrepreneurship | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Running a mathematical thinking club.</li> </ul>                                                              |
| Lifestyle choices       | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Creating a poster to reflect mathematical well-being.</li> </ul>                                              |

## The early mathematics learner

Play and exploration are vital to the learning and application of mathematical knowledge, particularly for younger learners. In a PYP learning environment, mathematics activities occur in safe, stimulating, and inviting learning spaces. In this environment, learners are actively involved in a range of experiences, guided or self-directed, to address wonderings and natural curiosities. The development of a variety of mathematical behaviours is supported as learners engage in play and inquiry, including:

- using mathematical language, objects and drawings to express ideas
- posing wonderings and asking questions
- identifying and managing information
- exploring and creating mathematical situations to develop their emergent understanding of mathematics concepts and skills
- identifying relationships
- actively engaging in learning
- developing a love of mathematics and learning.

Learners have access to a variety of resources to ensure they encounter situations that introduce them to a variety of mathematics concepts. Educators optimize learning during play by intentionally and purposefully planning for meaningful learning. They observe and listen carefully to discover, reflect on and grow learners’ understanding of mathematics concepts while developing positive mathematics behaviours.

To learn more about the early learner, refer to *Primary Years Programme: From principles into practice* > *The learner* > “**The early learner**”.

## The mathematics educator

Mathematics educators are themselves reflective inquirers, learning about their students’ unique experiences and interests, knowledge, skills, and understanding to personalize learning.

In designing learning experiences and units of inquiry, educators have the agency to ensure their planning is responsive to the mathematics needs of learners. They design open-ended learning experiences with an awareness of how barriers to learning can occur, working to address these barriers. Through collaboration with others within and beyond the learning community, educators develop their knowledge of mathematics and mathematics learning for all their learners.

The following examples of practice may serve as a guide, but the list is not exhaustive and may be added to according to the context of your school.

- Consider how students learn mathematics developmentally when planning for learning (i.e., additive thinking > multiplicative thinking)
- Use mathematics as an avenue for inquiry
- Incorporate a variety of modalities
- Consider the students as personal and cultural resources when planning for learning (Lewison, Harste, 2015)
- Consider where students are along various learning mathematics strands
- Elicit students’ mathematical thinking with “rich” tasks (i.e., open questions and parallel tasks) (Small, 2020)
- Incorporate experiences intended to develop mental mathematics strategies
- Incorporate experiences intended to enhance mathematical fluency
- Facilitate mathematical discourse for the purpose of making connections between ideas
- Model mathematics language
- Design collaborative experiences to develop creative and critical thinking

## Mathematics in the learning community

Every school community is unique, welcoming and inclusive, providing a space where learners and their families see themselves, their language, and culture reflected; feel safe, valued, and a sense of belonging.

Relationships are built with learners, staff, parents, guardians, and the wider community. These relationships, within the school’s inclusive and safe environment, foster a positive mathematics culture, exploring diverse perspectives and supporting the development of international-mindedness. To develop these relationships, educators and learners are encouraged to engage with the community and invite them into the school.

The following table illustrates how mathematics can play a role at all levels of the learning community. These examples are not exhaustive and can be adapted and added to within your own context.

Table 12

### *Mathematics in the learning community*

| Mathematics in the learning community                                                                                                                                                  |                                                                                                                                                                         |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Reaching out to the community                                                                                                                                                          | Inviting the community in                                                                                                                                               |
| <b>Classroom</b> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Apply a pattern to create a dance</li> <li>• Provide feedback to a peer during or after a problem-solving process</li> </ul> | <b>Classroom</b> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Share personal mathematical experiences from home that represent cultural and linguistic diversity</li> </ul> |

| Mathematics in the learning community                                                                                                                                                                                                        |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Reaching out to the community                                                                                                                                                                                                                | Inviting the community in                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Create a mathematics mindset poster</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                        | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Engage in a mathematical activity virtually with another classroom from another city</li> </ul>                                                                                                           |
| <b>School</b> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Create a mathematical art gallery in a shared space</li> <li>Develop school-wide mathematics norms</li> <li>Foster peer mentoring or tutoring to share mathematical thinking</li> </ul> | <b>School</b> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Showcase mathematical thinking and invite other classes for a gallery walk</li> <li>Conduct a survey of mathematical wonders</li> <li>Develop community-based mathematical norms</li> </ul> |
| <b>The wider community</b> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Host or participate in a community mathematics night</li> <li>Organize trips to museums and art galleries</li> </ul>                                                       | <b>The wider community</b> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Invite guest speakers from the local finance community to the school</li> <li>Create a mathematical model of a local community system</li> </ul>                               |

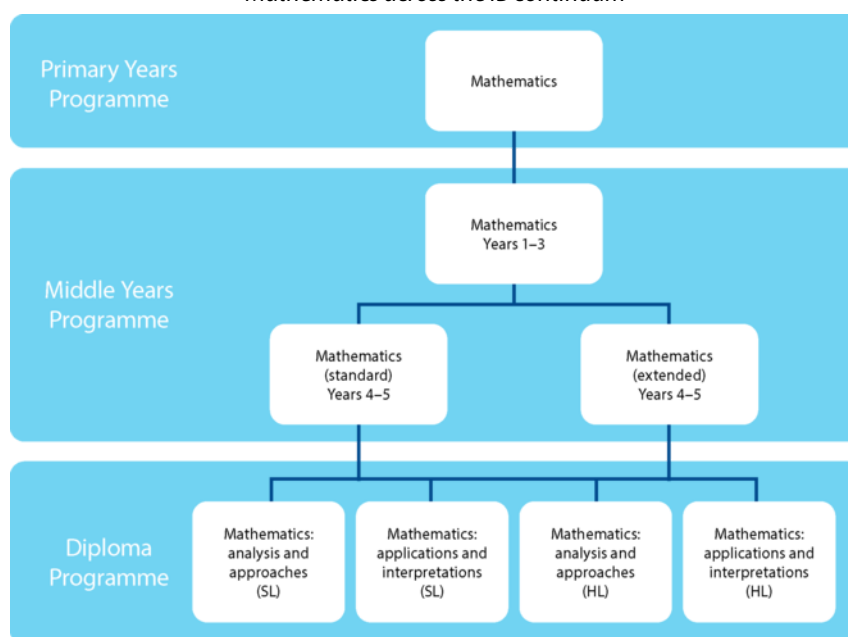
## Mathematics across the IB continuum

The IB's programmes provide a continuum of learning for learners aged 3–19. In the PYP, learning mathematics builds foundational skills and understanding, making mathematical thinking visible and responsive to those of others.

Learning experiences foster a deep appreciation for mathematics, enabling students to view the world through mathematics with confidence and competence.

This understanding connects mathematics to the world around them. They build a foundation of knowledge, skills, and conceptual understandings that can be further developed in the MYP, DP, and CP.

Figure 4  
Mathematics across the IB continuum



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# Personal, social and physical education: Subject overview

## Introduction

The purpose of this section is to provide an overview of the subject of personal, social and physical education in the PYP.

There are a number of aspects to consider in personal, social and physical education and learning in the PYP. These are addressed through focused guidance sections which can be read along with teacher support materials and tools that help scaffold the PYP in practice. These include the following.

- *Subject continuums: Personal, social and physical education*
- *Subject continuums: Arts*
- *The impact of the PYP on student well-being (2020)*
- *Inquiry learning progressions*
- *Primary Years Programme: From principles into practice > The learner > “The early learner”*

## Personal, social and physical education

Well-being is an integral aspect of personal, social and physical education. It is a continuous evolution of awareness and understanding of the physical, cognitive, and social-emotional facets of oneself, from which a responsible and resilient approach to life can develop. The ability to navigate life's challenges and complexities and to recognize, express, and self-regulate emotions with compassion can pave the way for caring and respectful connections with others and the planet (Dix, Sniedze-Gregory, 2020).

The school and wider community create the conditions for authentic individual and collective expression and engagement, fostering a sense of belonging and connectedness. Successful well-being strategies in the school context are widely regarded as embedding a balance of physical, cognitive and social-emotional learning opportunities (Falkenberg, 2023).

## Personal, social and physical education in the PYP

Personal, social and physical education is integral to learning and teaching in the PYP and is embodied in the IB learner profile that permeates the programme and represents the qualities of internationally minded students and effective lifelong learners. Within the PYP framework, personal, social and physical education plays a pivotal role in nurturing learners' comprehensive well-being, holistic health, and overall development. Personal, social and physical education fosters a foundation of confidence, competence, understanding, and a desire for engaging in active, healthy personal, social and physical activities that extend far beyond the classroom.

Personal, social and physical education in PYP includes four strands:

- identity
- interactions
- wellness
- movement.

For more information on the four strands, refer to [\*Subject continuums: Personal, social and physical education\*](#)

## Personal, social and physical education and transdisciplinary learning

By fostering the development of knowledge, values, skills, and conceptual understandings that contribute to individual and collective health and well-being, personal, social and physical education embodies and promotes a holistic approach to well-being and the development of the IB learner profile. As an integral part of the PYP curriculum, personal, social and physical education is intricately interwoven into every aspect of learning and teaching, permeating all learning contexts through both explicit and implicit pedagogical practices.

As concepts of global significance, personal and social health and well-being of people and the planet underpin the six transdisciplinary themes. Hence, personal, social and physical education focuses both on **learning about** practices of health and well-being and **learning through** practices of being personally, socially, and physically healthy and well. Both dimensions help learners develop approaches to learning skills within the curriculum and beyond.

The school's programme of inquiry provides a relevant and authentic context for learners to engage with personal, social and physical education. Wherever possible, personal, social and physical education should be taught through the units of inquiry and support learners' curiosities. It is also recognized that, at times,



there may be a need for units which are planned separately, but which connect through, for example, concepts, a line of inquiry, or the IB learner profile. Units are planned based on the interests and emerging theories of learners and units support learners in making connections between the different aspects of their learning.

# Concepts

Concepts are fundamental, abstract ideas (often encapsulated in one word) that support the development of conceptual understanding. The PYP identifies seven specified concepts that facilitate planning for a conceptual approach to transdisciplinary and subject-specific learning. Alongside these specified concepts, other concepts are explored within and outside units of inquiry (*Primary Years Programme: From principles into practice > Learning and teaching > “Conceptual understanding in the PYP”*, 2025).

## Specified concepts

Specified concepts are a key element of the PYP framework. They guide the planning of meaningful personal, social and physical education learning experiences intended to embrace learning and teaching through inquiry.

When explored as questions, these concepts enable purposeful and manageable inquiry. (*Primary Years Programme: From principles into practice > Learning and teaching > “Conceptual understanding in the PYP”*, 2025). These questions, used flexibly by educators and learners when planning an inquiry-based unit, shape that unit, giving it direction.

The following table explains each concept from the perspective of personal, social and physical education.

Table 13

*Specified concepts from the perspective of personal, social and physical education*

| Specified concept                                      | Generic perspective                                                                                                                  | Personal, social and physical education perspective                                                                                                                               |
|--------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Form</b><br>What is it like?                        | The understanding that everything has a form with recognizable features that can be observed, identified, described and categorized. | The features of personal, social and physical development—including feelings, beliefs, behaviours and movements—can be observed, identified, and described.                       |
| <b>Function</b><br>How does it work?                   | The understanding that everything has a purpose, a role or a way of behaving that can be investigated.                               | An examination of the feelings, beliefs, behaviours, and movements affecting our interactions with others and the environment.                                                    |
| <b>Causation</b><br>Why is it as it is?                | The understanding that things do not just happen; there are causal relationships at work, and that actions have consequences.        | Our personal, social, and physical well-being, as well as our relationships, are influenced by our feelings, beliefs, behaviours, and movements, and the factors that cause them. |
| <b>Change</b><br>How is it changing?                   | The understanding that change is the process of movement from one state to another. It is universal and inevitable.                  | The inevitable personal, social, and physical development and change over time are influenced by intrinsic and extrinsic factors.                                                 |
| <b>Connection</b><br>How is it linked to other things? | The understanding that we live in a world of interacting systems in                                                                  | An individual’s physical, emotional, and social development comprises interacting elements, including the                                                                         |

| Specified concept                                  | Generic perspective                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       | Personal, social and physical education perspective                                                                                                                     |
|----------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|                                                    | which the actions of any individual element affect others.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                | behaviour of others and the environment.                                                                                                                                |
| <b>Perspective</b><br>What are the points of view? | The understanding that knowledge is not neutral, is incomplete, and is socially and contextually constructed; it can be influenced by different points of view which lead to different interpretations, understandings and findings; perspectives may be individual, group, cultural or subject-specific. | Different perspectives of beliefs, feelings, and behaviours lead to diverse understandings of the world, including participation in and enjoyment of physical activity. |
| <b>Responsibility</b><br>What are our obligations? | The understanding that people make choices based on their understandings, beliefs and values, and the actions they take have intended and unintended impacts and consequences.                                                                                                                            | Making informed and appropriate choices lead to responsible actions, making a positive impact on our health, well-being, community, and the environment.                |

## Examples of questions that illustrate the specified concepts

The following table provides example of personal, social and physical education questions that illustrate the specified concepts, which may help structure or frame an inquiry. These examples demonstrate broad, open-ended questioning—requiring investigation, discussion, and a full and considered response—that is essential in an inquiry-based programme.

Table 14

### Example questions illustrating specified concepts in personal, social and physical education

| Specified concept                       | Example questions                                                                                                                                                                                                   |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
|-----------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|                                         | Personal and social education                                                                                                                                                                                       | Physical education                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| <b>Form</b><br>What is it like?         | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>What shapes our sense of identity?</li> <li>What physical and emotional characteristics define us?</li> <li>What are our rights and responsibilities?</li> </ul>             | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>What forms of physical activity promote collaboration and teamwork?</li> <li>What different shapes can you make on the floor using your body?</li> <li>What are the basic rules in this event/game?</li> </ul> |
| <b>Function</b><br>How does it work?    | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>How do rules help us to play?</li> <li>How are marginalised groups treated by society?</li> <li>How do different roles create a sense of community and belonging?</li> </ul> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>How do we collect and document results?</li> <li>How do you score points in your event/game?</li> <li>How do rules and strategies in sports promote a sense of belonging?</li> </ul>                           |
| <b>Causation</b><br>Why is it as it is? | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>How do you feel when things do not go as planned?</li> </ul>                                                                                                                 | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Why does your body change when you exercise?</li> <li>Why do people dance?</li> </ul>                                                                                                                          |

| Specified concept                                      | Example questions                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
|--------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|                                                        | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>What things make you feel like you belong?</li> <li>What things can harm your body?</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                          | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Why do we engage in physical activities together?</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| <b>Change</b><br>How is it changing?                   | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>What would you change about how you work together, if anything?</li> <li>How do you adapt to changes within a group or community?</li> <li>What lifestyle changes could you make to achieve a better balance?</li> </ul>                | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>How do our bodies adapt to different physical challenges?</li> <li>How does your coordination and balance change as you grow?</li> <li>How can you use your body to make different shapes?</li> </ul>                                                            |
| <b>Connection</b><br>How is it linked to other things? | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>What can we learn from playing with others?</li> <li>How is our classroom similar to a home?</li> <li>How are rights and responsibilities related?</li> </ul>                                                                           | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>How do physical activities connect us to our local community?</li> <li>How can you work as a group to achieve a common aim?</li> <li>How can your body movements show a mood or emotion?</li> </ul>                                                              |
| <b>Perspective</b><br>What are the points of view?     | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>What is easy/difficult about working together?</li> <li>How can we understand other people's perspectives and help them understand ours?</li> <li>How can considering different perspectives enhance our sense of belonging?</li> </ul> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Which piece of balance equipment do you enjoy use the most, and why?</li> <li>Why might different people have different opinions about what is fair in a game?</li> <li>How do different cultures approach physical fitness and well-being?</li> </ul>           |
| <b>Responsibility</b><br>What are our obligations?     | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>How do our actions affect others and the collective well-being?</li> <li>What responsibilities do we have to our community and the environment?</li> <li>How can we work together to create positive change?</li> </ul>                 | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>How can you ensure everyone has an opportunity to contribute their ideas and skills?</li> <li>How can we ensure a safe and inclusive environment for all students during physical activities?</li> <li>Why is warming up important before exercising?</li> </ul> |

## Other concepts

The specified concepts for personal, social and physical education are supported by additional concepts selected in response to the unit's goals and the needs and interests of learners. Examples include concepts such as diversity, identity, choices, resilience, and coordination.

For further examples of concepts that can be explored through personal, social and physical education, as well as subject-specific concepts, refer to [Subject continuums: Personal, social and physical education](#).

## The personal, social and physical education learner

Personal, social and physical education empowers learners to develop their language skills, knowledge, and understandings, fostering the growth of well-rounded individuals who embody the attributes of the IB learner profile. Through exploring diverse modes of communication, personal, social and physical education learners acquire the ability to access and make sense of their emotions, thoughts, and feelings, as well as to interpret and understand the world around them.

### Agency and the personal, social and physical education learner

The PYP nurtures curious inquirers, equipping them with the skills, knowledge, and conceptual understandings necessary for engaged and active lifelong learning. The culminating exhibition in the final year of the PYP provides an opportunity to practise and demonstrate student agency, and the IB learner profile attributes.

Exercising agency, personal, social and physical education learners take ownership of their learning, express their ideas and opinions, and reflect on their development of the IB learner profile attributes and their well-being. The IB learner profile empower learners to develop international-mindedness and take action for positive change. As agentic, active learners in personal, social and physical education, learners actively construct meaning and explore concepts, revise their understanding, and direct their learning around their own personal, social, physical health, and well-being.

### Action and the personal, social and physical education learner

Personal, social and physical education learners can apply their knowledge and understanding of personal, social and physical health and well-being to take individual and or collective action to address authentic problems or make positive changes in the local or global community and provoke reflection.

Table 15

*Demonstrations of actions in personal, social and physical education*

| Action                  | Personal, social and physical education examples could include the following.                                                                                |
|-------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Participation           | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Invite community members into school to enjoy a sports event, tournament, or game.</li> </ul>                         |
| Advocacy                | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Create posters or graphics to inform the community about an issue of importance to the learners.</li> </ul>           |
| Social justice          | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Explore issues of fairness from different perspectives.</li> </ul>                                                    |
| Social entrepreneurship | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Lead a mindfulness group for interested peers.</li> </ul>                                                             |
| Lifestyle choices       | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Run a campaign on the influences of the environment on personal, social and physical health and well-being</li> </ul> |

### The early personal, social and physical education learner

Play helps early learners explore their feelings and identities, both as individuals and as part of a community. Through their senses and movement, they discover the world around them, learning to connect and communicate with others. When early learners feel safe, they develop skills to understand their own emotions and those of others, becoming resilient and ready to learn. Physical health is crucial for young learners' cognitive development, sensory awareness, and motor skills. Indoor and outdoor play provides opportunities for early learners to build their strength, coordination, and sensory skills, and to engage and express themselves.

Additionally, playing with others, including their peers and members of the learning community, learners develop self-regulation skills, such as emotional regulation, turn-taking, conflict resolution, and respect for rules. These interactions lay the foundation for success in various life areas (Early Years Coalition, 2021).

To learn more about the early learner, refer to *Primary Years Programme: From principles into practice* > *The learner* > “**The early learner**”.

## The personal, social and physical education educator

In many schools, single-subject educators teach personal, social and physical education, but they should consider themselves PYP educators who contribute to the overall outcomes of a transdisciplinary programme through physical education. By collaborating with other educators, they can foster a holistic approach to learner well-being through collaboration, dialogue, and reflection. Regular collaboration ensures consistent promotion of health and well-being throughout the school’s programme of inquiry. Every educator is responsible for supporting each learner’s personal, social and physical development and well-being, both within and outside the programme of inquiry.

The following examples of practice may serve as a guide, but the list is not exhaustive and may be added to according to context of your school.

- Use personal, social and physical education to develop inquiry skills such as observation, questioning, and investigation
- Develop positive attitudes and behaviours of learners to meet challenges, address conflict, make healthy lifestyle choices, and become responsible, respectful members of society
- Involve the learning community in personal and social education learning experiences
- Promote physical literacy through deliberate practice, well-designed learning engagements, and creating space for learner agency
- Model personal, social and physical education language

Further reading: *Inquiry learning progressions*

## Personal, social and physical education in the learning community

Every school community is unique, welcoming and inclusive, providing a space where learners and their families see themselves, their language, and culture reflected; feel safe, valued, and a sense of belonging.

Relationships are built with learners, staff, parents, guardians, and the wider community. These relationships, within the school’s inclusive and safe environment, foster a positive personal, social and physical education culture, exploring diverse perspectives and supporting the development of international-mindedness. To develop these relationships, educators and learners are encouraged to engage with the community and invite them into the school.

The following table illustrates how personal, social and physical education can play a role at all levels of the learning community. These examples are not exhaustive and can be adapted and added to within your own context.

Table 16

*Personal, social and physical education in the learning community*

| Personal, social and physical education in the learning community                                                                        |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Reaching out to the community                                                                                                            | Inviting the community in                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| <b>Classroom</b> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Participate in a peer’s conversation or discussion about well-being</li> </ul> | <b>Classroom</b> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Share personal stories from home that represent culture diversity and identity</li> <li>• Ensure diversity in the provided materials, artefacts, and tools</li> </ul> |

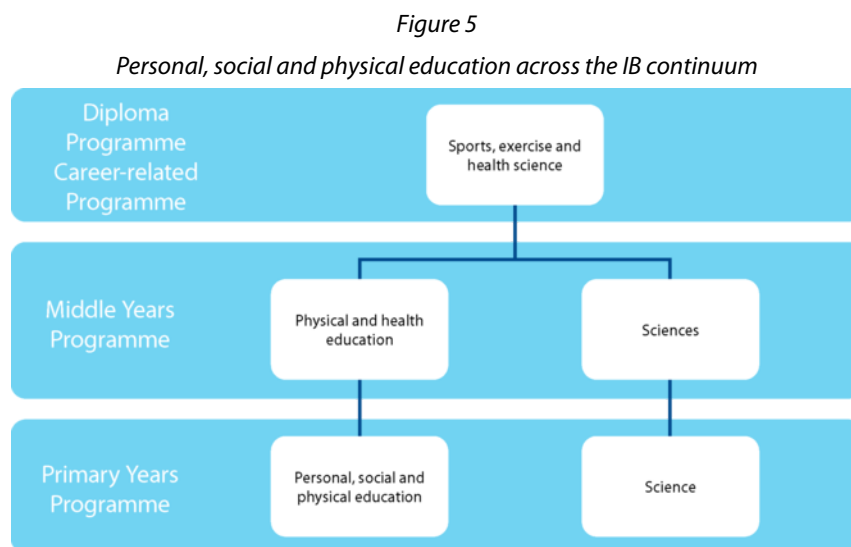
| Personal, social and physical education in the learning community                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Reaching out to the community                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     | Inviting the community in                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Provide feedback to a peer during or after a game or performance</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                                                              |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| <b>School</b> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Ensure strategies are in place to support transitions from class-to-class and school-to-school</li> <li>• Foster peer mentoring or tutoring to share knowledge and skills, for example, teach younger learners how to nurture the school garden</li> </ul> | <b>School</b> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Support learners' participation in extracurricular and community-based activities</li> <li>• Bring classes and schools together to share strategies for personal, social and physical health and well-being</li> </ul> |
| <b>The wider community</b> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Organize a wellness campaign within the local community</li> <li>• Lead nature hikes, outdoor sports camps, or school yard activities</li> </ul>                                                                                              | <b>The wider community</b> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Invite guest speakers from the personal, social and physical health and well-being community to the school</li> <li>• Engage with well-being related issues in the news or on social media</li> </ul>     |

# Personal, social and physical education across the IB curriculum

The IB's programmes provide a continuum of learning for learners aged 3–19. In the PYP, personal, social and physical education focuses on developing knowledge, skills, and attitudes that foster well-being for individuals and others. The MYP physical and health education aims to build on what learners learn and do in the PYP and other learner-centred programmes of primary education. There are no prior formal learning requirements needed for MYP.

MYP physical and health education courses, in combination with MYP sciences, help prepare learners for the study of sports, exercise and health science in the DP and CP. This rigorous course enables learners to inquire into systems of the human body and explore how and why these systems work together. In their study of sports, exercise and health science, learners apply their knowledge and understanding by critically analysing human performance and through planning and conducting laboratory investigations.

Figure 5 illustrates the IB continuum pathways to DP/CP sports, exercise and health science.





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# Science: Subject overview

## Introduction

The purpose of this section is to provide an overview of the subject of science in the PYP.

There are several aspects to consider in science and learning in the PYP. These are addressed through focused guidance sections which can be read along with teacher support materials and tools that help scaffold the PYP in practice. These include the following publications:

- *Subject continuums: Science*
- *Inquiry learning progressions*
- *Primary Years Programme: From principles into practice* > *The learner* > **"The early learner"**

# Science

The nature of science explores the biological, chemical, and physical aspects of the natural world, highlighting our interconnectedness with nature and the relationships between these aspects. Inquiry is fundamental to science. Through inquiry, learners discover and investigate the world around them. Science provides a language to express wonder and communicate about **phenomena**, explore theories, and make connections to build scientific understanding of the world. As principled learners, they make informed decisions, draw conclusions, and reflect on the process.

## Science in the PYP

The inclusion of science within the PYP leads learners to an appreciation and awareness of the world from a scientific perspective. Curiosity inspires classroom inquiry, sparking exploration of varied scientific principles, phenomena and innovations. There are numerous applications where scientific knowledge, skills, and concepts are made relevant.

Science in the PYP includes three strands.

- Living things
- Earth and space
- Physical and chemical

For more information on the three strands, refer to the [Subject continuums: Science](#)

Reflection on scientific knowledge helps students develop a sense of responsibility for the impact of their actions on themselves, others, and their surroundings, transcending boundaries. This supports the development of international-mindedness. A solid foundational understanding of science in the PYP enables learners to pose investigable questions, evaluate findings, balance scientific arguments, and supports them to use science to take action.

## Science and transdisciplinary learning

Whenever possible, science should be taught through the relevant, authentic context of the programme of inquiry. Connections to the transdisciplinary themes should be explicitly made.

The transdisciplinary themes offer a structured framework for an in-depth inquiry-based programme, where strong connections with science can be made. These connections enrich both science learning and the exploration of transdisciplinary themes. Spontaneous science inquiries, though not directly tied to planned units, provide valuable learning experiences, aligning with the PYP. Schools with specific local, national, and regional curriculum requirements can integrate required scientific knowledge into their programme of inquiry.

Successful science learning enables students to extract key ideas, pose open-ended questions, provide accurate explanations, and take meaningful action. This cultivates lifelong learning habits and attitudes.

The science component of the curriculum also provides opportunities for students to:

- explore and develop subject-specific knowledge, skills, and conceptual understandings
- identify the possible causes of an issue, choose a solution, and determine appropriate action to be taken
- consider scientific models and applications of these models (including their limitations)
- evaluate the different roles of scientists in society such as to debate, and challenge views and theories to draw conclusions.

# Concepts

Concepts are fundamental, abstract ideas (often encapsulated in one word) that support the development of conceptual understanding. The PYP identifies seven specified concepts that facilitate planning for a conceptual approach to transdisciplinary and subject-specific learning. Alongside these specified concepts, other concepts are explored within and outside units of inquiry (*Primary Years Programme: From principles into practice > Learning and teaching > "Conceptual understanding in the PYP"*, 2025).

## Specified concepts

Specified concepts are a key element of the PYP framework. They guide the planning of meaningful science learning experiences intended to embrace learning and teaching through inquiry.

When explored as questions, these concepts enable purposeful and manageable inquiry. (*Primary Years Programme: From principles into practice > Learning and teaching > "Conceptual understanding in the PYP"*, 2025). These questions, used flexibly by educators and students when planning an inquiry-based unit, shape that unit, and giving it direction.

The following table explains each concept from the perspective of science.

Table 17

*Specified concepts from the perspective of science*

| Specified concept                                      | Generic perspective                                                                                                                  | Science perspective                                                                                                                                                               |
|--------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Form</b><br>What is it like?                        | The understanding that everything has a form with recognizable features that can be observed, identified, described and categorized. | Most things have a form or shape with an outward or visible manifestation and an internal structure.                                                                              |
| <b>Function</b><br>How does it work?                   | The understanding that everything has a purpose, a role or a way of behaving that can be investigated.                               | The special activities, properties or purposes, natural or endowed, of a creature or thing.                                                                                       |
| <b>Causation</b><br>Why is it as it is?                | The understanding that things do not just happen; there are causal relationships at work, and that actions have consequences.        | The effect brought about by an intended or unintended action or reaction.                                                                                                         |
| <b>Change</b><br>How is it changing?                   | The understanding that change is the process of movement from one state to another. It is universal and inevitable.                  | An inevitable aspect of the physical world as things become different or pass from one form to another. It can be natural or brought about and accelerated by outside influences. |
| <b>Connection</b><br>How is it linked to other things? | The understanding that we live in a world of interacting systems in which the actions of any individual element affect others.       | The world is full of interacting systems that depend on each other to form a working whole.                                                                                       |
| <b>Perspective</b><br>What are the points of view?     | The understanding that knowledge is not neutral, is incomplete, and is socially and                                                  | Events and findings can be interpreted differently, depending on knowledge, experience, and                                                                                       |

| Specified concept                                  | Generic perspective                                                                                                                                                                                                  | Science perspective                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
|----------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|                                                    | contextually constructed; it can be moderated by different points of view which lead to different interpretations, understandings and findings; perspectives may be individual, group, cultural or subject-specific. | motives. The difference between empirically proven facts and supposition must be emphasized.                                                                                                                                         |
| <b>Responsibility</b><br>What are our obligations? | The understanding that people make choices based on their understandings, beliefs and values, and the actions they take have intended and unintended impacts and consequences.                                       | We have a responsibility to the world we live in. This involves being aware of how scientific knowledge can be used to improve or worsen the quality of life of all living things. Responsibility entails both action and awareness. |

### Examples of questions that illustrate the specified concepts

The following table provides example science questions that illustrate the specified concepts, and which may help structure or frame an inquiry. These examples demonstrate broad, open-ended questioning—requiring investigation, discussion, and a full and considered response—that is essential in an inquiry-based programme.

Table 18

#### Example questions illustrating the specified concepts in science

| Specified concept                                      | Example questions                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
|--------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Form</b><br>What is it like?                        | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>If the Earth were cut in half between the North Pole and the South Pole, what would its interior look like?</li> <li>What are the components of an ecosystem?</li> </ul>                                                                                              |
| <b>Function</b><br>How does it work?                   | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>What can shadows be used for?</li> <li>How is air used around us?</li> <li>What do reservoirs and purification plants do?</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                  |
| <b>Causation</b><br>Why is it as it is?                | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Why are different foods processed differently?</li> <li>How are houses constructed to suit local climates around the world?</li> <li>What causes the changes that occur during puberty?</li> </ul>                                                                    |
| <b>Change</b><br>How is it changing?                   | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>How does sand change from morning to afternoon?</li> <li>What differences do you observe in plant growth over time?</li> <li>How does air differ from place to place and over time?</li> </ul>                                                                        |
| <b>Connection</b><br>How is it linked to other things? | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Why are certain vehicles suitable for specific tasks?</li> <li>How does the human life cycle compare to that of other animals?</li> <li>What are the similarities and differences between your local ecosystem and a larger ecosystem you have researched?</li> </ul> |
| <b>Perspective</b><br>What are the points of view?     | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>What different points of view are supported by the evidence?</li> <li>How does science explain the existence of the Earth, solar system, and galaxy?</li> <li>What are the implications for humans?</li> </ul>                                                        |

| Specified concept                                  | Example questions                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
|----------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Responsibility</b><br>What are our obligations? | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• How can we avoid wasting water?</li> <li>• What factors should you consider when designing and making a vehicle?</li> <li>• What steps can we take remain healthy?</li> </ul> |

## Other concepts

The specified concepts for science are supported by additional concepts selected in response to the unit's goals and the needs and interests of learners. Examples include concepts, such as **systems, patterns, sustainability** and **innovation**.

For further examples of concepts that can be explored through the science, as well as subject-specific concepts, refer to the *Subject continuums: Science*.

## The science learner

In the PYP, science learners actively build their understanding of the world by integrating scientific knowledge with critical thinking and reasoning. As they inquire into the world and grow their understanding of scientific concepts, they also develop a sense of responsibility. Through reflection, learners consider the impact of their actions on themselves, others, and the environment. This promotes a holistic understanding of their role in the world.

As scientists they:

- engage in hands-on learning experiences to foster scientific inquiry and questioning
- express wonderings
- select and use appropriate tools to measure data accurately
- use scientific vocabulary to explain their observations and experiences
- embrace uncertainty and ambiguity
- engage in discussions, dialogue, and data interpretation
- propose scientific explanations to justify **hypotheses**
- understand multiple perspectives in science, and consider applications for them
- play, participate, experiment and iterate in scaffolded, guided and independent investigations
- work both individually and collectively
- make informed choices.

## Agency and the science learner

Learner agency is rooted in the principle that learners have the ability and the will to positively influence their own lives and the world around them. Learners strive to make sense of their lives and the world around them by constructing meaning, exploring concepts, revising understanding, and directing their learning.

Learners then become agents in their own learning, demonstrating critical thinking and problem-solving skills. This enables them to analyse information, identify biases, and devise solutions to authentic challenges. The culminating exhibition in the final year of the PYP provides an opportunity to practise and demonstrate student agency, and the IB learner profile attributes.

## Action and the science learner

Taking action involves applying knowledge and understanding gained through scientific inquiry to address authentic problems or make positive changes in the local or global community.

As a scientist, learners can use their understanding of science to take individual or collective action, provoking ethical thinking and inspiring innovation.

As curious, creative, and reflective community members, learners strive to make a difference to address authentic problems or make positive changes in the local or global community and provoke reflection.

Table 19  
*Demonstrations of action in science*

| Action                  | Science examples could include the following.                                                                                                        |
|-------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Participation           | Actively participating in initiatives related to environmental sustainability, health, or social factors or challenges.                              |
| Advocacy                | Writing letters, initiating or taking part in, a campaign to positively support and mobilize local community members in their rights to clean water. |
| Social justice          | Exploring issues of fairness, such as access to quality local food and exportation and importation, from different perspectives.                     |
| Social entrepreneurship | Starting a community recycling service to collect and sort recyclables for pickup.                                                                   |
| Lifestyle choices       | Hosting a healthy cooking class to learn how to prepare nutritious meals and snacks at home.                                                         |

## The early science learner

Early learners are naturally curious about their environment, actively constructing meaning through playful interactions with the physical world. In play, they construct, test, confirm, or revise their working theories, individually or with their peers, constantly adapting their personal models of how the world works. They use their senses to gather information, explore and identify patterns, make predictions, and discuss their thinking. Within a collaborative and supportive setting, young learners' curiosity is sparked, and a sense of wonder is developed, laying the foundation for a life-long love of science.

To learn more about the early learner, refer to [Primary Years Programme: From principles into practice > The learner > "The early learner"](#).

## The science educator

Science educators are themselves reflective inquirers, learning about their students' unique experiences and interests, knowledge, skills, and understanding to personalize learning.

In designing learning experiences and units of inquiry, educators have the agency to ensure their planning is responsive to the science needs of learners. They design open-ended learning experiences with an awareness of how barriers to learning can occur, working to address these barriers. Through collaboration with others within and beyond the learning community, educators develop their knowledge of science and science learning for all their learners.

The following examples of practice serve as a guide, but the list is not exhaustive and may be added to according to the context of your school.

- Collaborate with classroom educators and other single-subject educators, to plan and develop central ideas, incorporating their input
- Guide students to formulate their own questions
- Build connections between students' experiences and the information and processes obtained from the inquiry into new understandings.
- Provide opportunities to support students to engage in their own inquiries
- Promote learner reflection and action in response to their learning

- Design learning experiences and assessments that are inclusive for diverse students, and provide access to a variety of external resources and settings
- Model scientific language

## Science in the learning community

In a learning community, science is explored through hands-on, inquiry-based methods, fostering shared discovery through collaboration. Integration of technology and diverse perspectives enriches the learning experience, connecting students to real-world applications.

Relationships are built with learners, staff, parents, guardians, and the wider community. These relationships, within the school's inclusive and safe environment, offer many opportunities for cultivating innovation and a lifelong appreciation for different perspectives in science. These relationships also support the development of international-mindedness. To develop these relationships, educators and learners are encouraged to engage with the community and invite them into the school.

The following table illustrates how science may play a role at all levels of the learning community. These examples are not exhaustive and can be adapted and added to within your own context.

Table 20

*Science in the learning community*

| Science in the learning community                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Reaching out to the community                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              | Inviting the community in                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| <b>Classroom</b> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Take care of the classroom pet</li> <li>• Provide feedback to a peer during or after an experiment</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                    | <b>Classroom</b> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Observe the environment through nature walks</li> <li>• Ensure diversity in the provided materials, artefacts, tools</li> </ul>                                     |
| <b>School</b> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Join a local science club to meet other learners interested in science</li> <li>• Foster peer mentoring or tutoring to share knowledge and skills. For example, teach younger learners how to take their heartbeat rate after exercising</li> </ul> | <b>School</b> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Participate in a school cleanup to keep parks and streets clean</li> <li>• Host a weather observation station to track and report on daily weather patterns</li> </ul> |
| <b>The wider community</b> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Organize trips to museums, botanical gardens, or parks</li> <li>• Participate in a community science project such as monitoring local wildlife or water quality</li> </ul>                                                             | <b>The wider community</b> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Invite guest speakers from the science community to the school</li> <li>• Engage with science related issues in the news or on social media</li> </ul>    |

## Science across the IB continuum

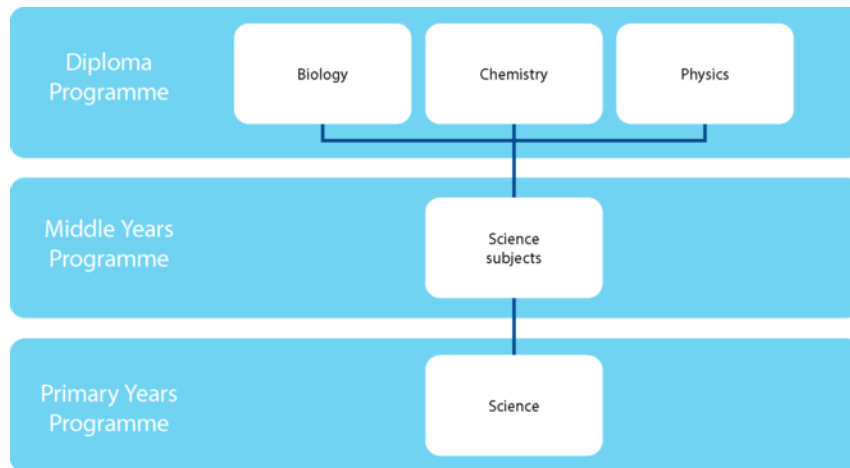
The IB's programmes provide a continuum of learning for learners aged 3–19. In the PYP, learning in science provides opportunities for learners to discover, explore and engage in their own inquiries. Learning in science challenges learners' thinking, as they make connections between diverse perspectives and develop understandings of their own.

Through these opportunities learners appreciate science as a mindset that embraces the wonders of science. In turn, they build a foundation of knowledge, skills, and conceptual understandings that can be



further developed in the MYP. The DP and CP offer learners the opportunity to focus on one area of science and to develop specialized knowledge, skills, and understandings within that subject.

*Figure 6*  
*Science across the IB continuum*



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# Social studies: Subject overview

## Introduction

The purpose of this section is to provide an overview of the subject of social studies in the PYP.

There are several aspects to consider in social studies and learning in the PYP. These are addressed through focused guidance sections which can be read along with teacher support materials and tools that help scaffold the PYP in practice. These include the following publications:

- *Subject continuums: Social studies*
- *Inquiry learning progressions*
- *Primary Years Programme: From principles into practice > The learner > “The early learner”*
- *Primary Years Programme: From principles into practice > Learning and teaching > “Transdisciplinary learning”*

## Social studies

Social studies is an exploration of “being in and with the world” (Biesta, 2022). In other words, being with ourselves and each other—through **place**, **space**, and **time** in recognition of the multiplicity of ways of knowing, being, and doing.

Social studies encompasses disciplines from the humanities including geography, history, economics, and philosophy as well as politics, law, sociology, psychology, religious studies, and anthropology. It seeks to activate learners’ curiosity about the world and foster a sense of belonging to, and responsibility towards, personal, local, and global communities.

In the context of our rapidly changing, volatile, uncertain, and complex world (Stein, 2021), and informed by the field of **global education and learning** social studies curriculums for early and primary learners have shifted globally. They now often include a stronger focus on global citizenship and sustainability, and related skills, attitudes and values such as critical thinking and reflection, ethics, and intercultural understanding.

## Social studies in the PYP

In the PYP, social studies draws from a wide range of subjects including but not limited to geography, history, economics, philosophy, and anthropology with central threads of global citizenship, and sustainability. As with all PYP subjects, the design of social studies learning is responsive to personal, local, and global contexts and the experiences, interests, perspectives and diversity of the learning community.

It seeks to engage learners in deep curiosities, observations and explorations of **human and natural worlds** past, present and future. Learners encounter and experience themselves as social and ecological beings, activating their intuition with wonder, awe, and wisdom. It also supports learners to explore their own and others’ identities, stories and histories as they investigate with intentionality and reflexivity in collaboration with others.

Social studies in the PYP includes four strands:

- Ways of knowing and systems
- Critical global citizenship and culture
- Continuity and change for reimagined futures
- Interconnected places, spaces and relationships

For more information on the four strands, refer to the [Subject continuums: Social studies](#).

## Social studies and transdisciplinary learning

The transdisciplinary themes provide a relevant, responsive and transformative curriculum structure for social studies, enabling learners to engage in authentic and meaningful inquiries. These themes serve as the starting point for learners’ critical engagement in local and global issues—an overarching and transformative rationale of social studies. Social studies, as with all PYP subjects, is wherever possible, integrated into units of inquiry. Sometimes there may be a need for subject-specific inquiry units to be planned, which connect to the transdisciplinary unit of inquiry through, for example, concepts, lines of inquiry, or action.

Social studies in the PYP remains at the heart of transdisciplinary learning because it is concerned with the intrinsic interdependence between social and ecological systems *and* the health and well-being of people and planet. It draws attention to the wider interdisciplinary and transdisciplinary ways in which local and global communities address challenges and opportunities.

The social studies component of the curriculum also provides opportunities for students to:

- explore and develop discipline-specific knowledge, skills, and conceptual understandings
- consider and apply social studies research methods, practices, and tools and their applications (including limitations and bias)
- participate as social scientists, cultivating awareness and engaging in social discourse in order to question norms, practices, and points of view
- engage with both material and non-material data and evidence
- collaborate in ethical, reciprocal, and compassionate ways
- participate in and contribute to disciplinary and transdisciplinary investigations
- evaluate the diverse roles and responsibilities social scientists have in diverse communities.

# Concepts

Concepts are fundamental, abstract ideas (often encapsulated in one word) that support the development of conceptual understanding. The PYP identifies seven specified concepts that facilitate planning for a conceptual approach to transdisciplinary and subject-specific learning. Alongside these specified concepts, other concepts are explored within and outside units of inquiry (*Primary Years Programme: From principles into practice > Learning and teaching > “Conceptual understanding in the PYP”, 2025*).

## Specified concepts

Specified concepts are a key element of the PYP framework. They guide the planning of meaningful social studies learning experiences intended to embrace learning and teaching through inquiry.

When explored as questions, these concepts enable purposeful and manageable inquiry (*Primary Years Programme: From principles into practice > Learning and teaching > “Conceptual understanding in the PYP”, 2025*). These questions, used flexibly by educators and students when planning an inquiry-based unit, shape that unit, giving it direction.

The following table explains each concept from the perspective of social studies.

Table 21

*Specified concepts from the perspective of social studies*

| Specified concept                                      | Generic perspective                                                                                                                  | Social studies perspective                                                                           |
|--------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Form</b><br>What is it like?                        | The understanding that everything has a form with recognizable features that can be observed, identified, described and categorized. | The recognizable features of human and natural places and spaces and of individuals and communities. |
| <b>Function</b><br>How does it work?                   | The understanding that everything has a purpose, a role or a way of behaving that can be investigated.                               | The components and dynamics of social and ecological systems.                                        |
| <b>Causation</b><br>Why is it as it is?                | The understanding that things do not just happen; there are causal relationships at work, and that actions have consequences.        | The causes, effects and impacts of phenomena.                                                        |
| <b>Change</b><br>How is it changing?                   | The understanding that change is the process of movement from one state to another. It is universal and inevitable.                  | The nature of dynamic and overlapping social and ecological shifts through time.                     |
| <b>Connection</b><br>How is it linked to other things? | The understanding that we live in a world of interacting systems in which the actions of any individual element affect others.       | The interrelationships and interactions between social and ecological systems.                       |
| <b>Perspective</b><br>What are the points of view?     | The understanding that knowledge is not neutral, is incomplete, and is socially and                                                  | The diverse and divergent ways in which humans experience being in and with the world.               |

| Specified concept                                  | Generic perspective                                                                                                                                                                                                  | Social studies perspective                                                                                           |
|----------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|                                                    | contextually constructed; it can be moderated by different points of view which lead to different interpretations, understandings and findings; perspectives may be individual, group, cultural or subject-specific. |                                                                                                                      |
| <b>Responsibility</b><br>What are our obligations? | The understanding that people make choices based on their understandings, beliefs and values, and the actions they take have intended and unintended impacts and consequences.                                       | Peoples' individual and collective responsibilities and accountabilities towards themselves, others, and the planet. |

## Examples of questions that illustrate the specified concepts

The following table provides example social studies questions that illustrate the specified concepts, which may help to structure or frame an inquiry. These examples demonstrate broad, open-ended questioning—requiring investigation, discussion, and a full considered responses—that is essential in an inquiry-based programme.

Table 22

### Example questions illustrating the specified concepts in social studies

| Specified concept                                      | Example questions                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
|--------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Form</b><br>What is it like?                        | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>What groups do I belong to and why?</li> <li>What rules, roles, and responsibilities are there in my school?</li> <li>What features are recognizable in our immediate and wider communities?</li> </ul>                                       |
| <b>Function</b><br>How does it work?                   | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>How do we relate to different communities?</li> <li>How has our community evolved over time?</li> <li>What are the components of systems and structures and how are they organized in different ways?</li> </ul>                              |
| <b>Causation</b><br>Why is it as it is?                | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>What drivers are connected to human movement?</li> <li>How do ways of relating affect communities?</li> <li>In what ways do beliefs, values, and practices shape our communities?</li> </ul>                                                  |
| <b>Change</b><br>How is it changing?                   | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>How have humans impacted the natural world?</li> <li>Why might local and traditional practices have changed over generations?</li> <li>What social dimensions of change are apparent/less apparent through place, space, and time?</li> </ul> |
| <b>Connection</b><br>How is it linked to other things? | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>How are our past, present and future interconnected?</li> <li>What is our relationship to other living and non-living entities?</li> </ul>                                                                                                    |

| Specified concept                                  | Example questions                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
|----------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|                                                    | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>How might world views be connected to ways of living and experiencing the world?</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| <b>Perspective</b><br>What are the points of view? | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>What do most people around me think about this?</li> <li>How can we acknowledge and challenge our own assumptions, biases, values, and attitudes?</li> <li>How can we represent divergent perspectives and world views?</li> <li>How might my perspective be the same or different if I lived in a different community?</li> </ul> |
| <b>Responsibility</b><br>What are our obligations? | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>What is my role and what is my responsibility towards others?</li> <li>How can we ensure our responses to local and global issues are collaboratively and reciprocally formed?</li> <li>Why is it important to critically reflect on taking action or deciding not to take action?</li> </ul>                                      |

## Other concepts

The specified concepts for social studies are supported by additional concepts selected in response to the unit's goals and the needs and interests of learners. Examples include concepts such as equality and equity, rights and responsibilities, uncertainty, cooperation, diversity, power, privilege, and identity.

For further examples of concepts that can be explored through social studies, as well as subject-specific concepts, refer to the [Subject continuums: Social studies](#).

## The social studies learner

Through personal and shared inquiries, the social studies learner investigates the past, the present, and considers future possibilities. They engage critically in experiences that can challenge, contribute, support and advocate for their communities and the wider world. Through their inquiries, they develop and demonstrate skills such as intentional and persistent observation, investigation, questioning, collaboration and critical thinking.

As social scientists, they:

- situate themselves and others in relation to human and natural worlds
- develop a sense of and attachment to place
- explore the diversity of human actions, practices, experiences, knowledge traditions, and stories through place, space, and time
- encounter, observe and interact in and with social and ecological systems
- participate in field work, experiential learning, immersive and place-based learning, and local and traditional practices
- play, participate, experiment, and iterate in investigations
- consider multiple ways of seeing the world
- engage with complexity, systems, and alternative futures.

## Agency and the social studies learner

Learner agency in social studies is rooted in the premise that learners are in dynamic, responsive, and reciprocal relationships with themselves and their communities (Hacking, Taylor, 2020). Through reflection,



participation, and collaboration, learners develop and demonstrate the attributes of the IB learner profile and to take action.

Through social studies, learners cultivate the skills to listen to and engage with diverse and pluralistic perspectives, fostering an environment of inclusive and compassionate dialogue. This active engagement enables learners to co-construct and reimagine futures, developing a sense of agency. The culminating exhibition in the final year of the PYP provides an opportunity to practise and demonstrate student agency, and the IB learner profile attributes.

## Action and the social studies learner

As young social scientists, learners can use their understanding of social and ecological systems to take individual or collective action. As curious, creative, and reflective community members, learners strive to make or ignite changes in the local or global community.

Table 23

### *Demonstrations of action in social studies*

| Action                  | Social studies examples could include the following.                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
|-------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Participation           | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Leading a student council focused on rights and responsibilities, and informed decision-making.</li> <li>Contributing to local, indigenous, or traditional ceremonies and practices.</li> </ul>                           |
| Advocacy                | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Planning and carrying out a campaign to support library book sharing services in the local community.</li> <li>Promoting awareness of a local landform or geographical feature of importance to the community.</li> </ul> |
| Social justice          | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Inquiring into carbon and ecological footprints in relation to fairness and justice.</li> <li>Critically reflecting on positions in relation to access to education.</li> </ul>                                           |
| Social entrepreneurship | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Initiating projects which support local, Indigenous, and traditional livelihoods.</li> <li>Organizing or leading student groups focusing on equity, diversity, and inclusion.</li> </ul>                                  |
| Lifestyle choices       | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Organizing school and community skills exchanges.</li> <li>Taking on a role of peer support in a local community space.</li> </ul>                                                                                        |

## The early social studies learner

Through play, early learners participate in indoor and outdoor experiential, embodied and place-based learning experiences. They explore their immediate social and physical surroundings, developing a sense of belonging, time, and place, and begin to *situate* themselves in relation to others (both human and natural).

In a collaborative, responsive, and supportive setting early social studies learners participate in a range of immersive experiences that activate their intuition and inquisitiveness.

To learn more about the early learner, refer to [Primary Years Programme: From principles into practice > The learner > “The early learner”](#).

## The social studies educator

In designing learning experiences and units of inquiry, educators have the agency to ensure their planning is responsive to the needs of learners. They design open-ended learning experiences with an awareness of how barriers to learning can occur, working to address these barriers. The following examples of practice

may serve as a guide, but the list is not exhaustive and may be added to according to the context of your school.

- Collaborate on planning units of inquiry focusing on immersive, embodied, and place-based pedagogies
- Use learners' questions, responses, hypotheses, and reflections to inform iterative inquiries
- Facilitate or contribute to intergenerational conversations, talks, exhibitions, and workshops
- Practise disciplinary language to make connections within, across, and beyond subjects
- Use social studies as an authentic context to develop inquiry skills such as observation, questioning, and investigation
- Support personal and collective action
- Organize and participate in field trips, experiential activities, and simulations

## Social studies in the learning community

Every school community is unique, welcoming and inclusive, providing a space where learners and their families see themselves, their language, and culture reflected; feel safe, valued, and a sense of belonging.

The following table illustrates how social studies can play a role at all levels of the learning community. These examples are not exhaustive and can be adapted and added to within your own context.

Table 24

*Social studies in the learning community*

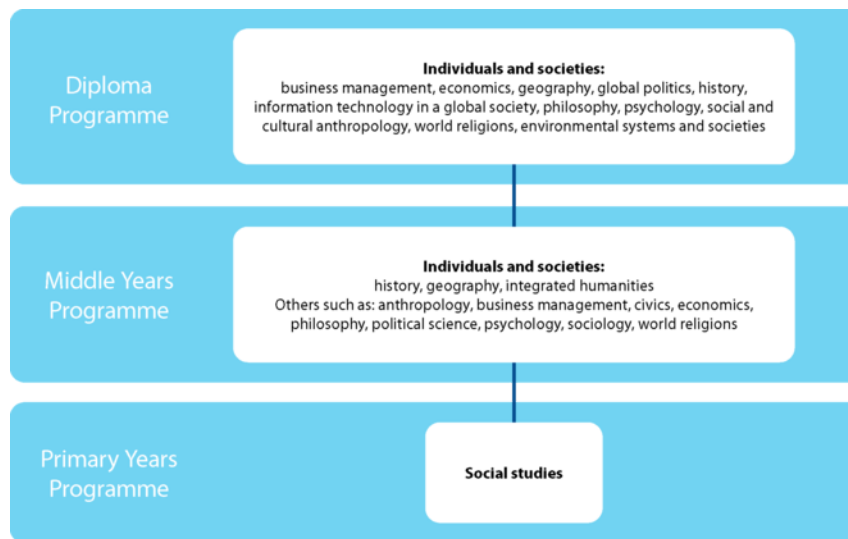
| Social studies in the learning community                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Reaching out to the community                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               | Inviting the community in                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| <b>Classroom</b> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Participate in reflective questioning in a local museum or place of significance</li> <li>• Represent diverse perspectives in a class debate about shared community spaces</li> </ul>                                                             | <b>Classroom</b> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Collect visual images of flora and fauna in preparation for a gallery walk</li> <li>• Create family trees and share connections between people and heritage</li> </ul>                          |
| <b>School</b> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Use senses to sketch a map of the school, noting significant places, markers, and seasonal patterns</li> <li>• Share personal stories of encounters with nature, telling and retelling stories of experiences, sightings, awe, and wonder</li> </ul> | <b>School</b> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Collaborate with partner classes to organize a local community walk</li> <li>• Conduct a survey of social studies skills and practices across the school and share it in a school event</li> </ul> |
| <b>The wider community</b> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Organize school trips to explore an archaeological or cultural site</li> <li>• Contribute to a community restoration project</li> </ul>                                                                                                 | <b>The wider community</b> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Invite local experts to run a workshop, presentation or debate</li> <li>• Engage with issues of social justice in the local community</li> </ul>                                      |

## Social studies and the IB continuum

The IB's programmes provide a continuum of learning for learners aged 3–19. In the PYP, learning in social studies continues in various iterations across the MYP, DP, and CP.

The following illustrates opportunities to both broaden and specialize in individuals and societies disciplines across the IB continuum of learning.

Figure 7  
Social studies across the IB continuum



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